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A BM-BME

Seek mining Act amendment reversal: Naveen to BJP MPs

It has far-reaching implications for the State; the control over our minerals, mineral-bearing lands has been taken away from us, says former Odisha CM in a letter addressed to the ruling party MPs

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Former Odisha Chief Minister and Biju Janata Dal (BJD) chief Naveen Patnaik on Saturday urged the State's Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MPs to challenge and call for a reversal of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026.

Odisha's contributions "August 13, 2026, which saw the passage of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, in the Lok Sabha with your support, was a black day for Odisha. The Bill was passed with less than ten minutes of discussion in the Lok Sabha, despite having provisions with far-reaching implications for the people of the State," Mr. Patnaik said in a letter addressed to BJP MPs.



August 13, when the Bill was passed with the BJP MPs' support, a 'black day' for Odisha, said Naveen Patnaik. FILE PHOTO

"This was not an ordinary piece of legislation. Odisha undoubtedly will be the worst affected by it. As you are well aware, Odisha accounts for nearly 44% of India's mineral wealth. For decades, Odisha has contributed its mineral wealth to the building of India's steel,

power, mining and infrastructure sectors," he mentioned.

"India stands taller and stronger today because of the contribution made by Odisha and her people. The estimated annual loss would be more than ₹12,000 crore, leading to lakhs of crores of rupees over time. But the bigger loss is that in a single legislative stroke, the control over our own minerals and our mineral-bearing lands was taken away from us. And this happened under your watch," Mr. Patnaik said.

Injustice to people "This law is an injustice to the children and youth of Odisha whose future is linked to the resources and opportunities of this State. It is an injustice to the people of Odisha who bear the pollution, displacement, environmental degradation and the hazards and

hardships of mining. And, above all, it is an injustice to the dream of an empowered Odisha that has the confidence and resources to determine its own future," he said.

Appealing to their conscience, Mr. Patnaik called on BJP MPs to advocate for the reversal of the MMDR Act amendment, citing its negative impact on Odisha's future.

"History remembers and honours those who raise their voice when injustice is done to their people and its resources. History will judge you not by the party you stood with, but by whether you stood up for Odisha when it mattered most. You are standing at a historic juncture with a choice to stand and fight for the State and the people who sent you to the Lok Sabha with a mandate to protect their interests," said the five-time CM in the letter.

'Final battle': Jarange-Patil begins indefinite hunger strike for Maratha quota

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil began an indefinite hunger strike at Antarwali Sarati in Jalna district on Saturday, reviving the reservation agitation and pressing the Maharashtra government to accept his demands, including the issuance of caste certificates based on the 58 lakh identified Kunbi records.

Addressing mediapersons at the protest site, Mr. Jarange-Patil said the government should not resort to delaying tactics. "Caste certificates and validity documents must be issued immediately based on the 58 lakh Kunbi records," he said.

"We will not give the government any additional time. This is the final battle. Every person should step out of their homes and participate in this fight," he added.

Mr. Jarange-Patil said the process of issuing



Maratha reservation activist Manoj Jarange-Patil. FILE PHOTO

Kunbi certificates to Marathas in Marathwada should be expedited based on the Hyderabad Gazetteer.

Other GRs

He also called for the implementation of government resolutions (GRs) related to the Aundh-Pune, Bombay Government and Satara Gazetteers.

"The government should not attempt to reduce the 58 lakh records identified by the Shinde committee or discard any of them. Certificates must be issued urgently on the

basis of all these records," he said.

March to Mumbai

Mr. Jarange-Patil warned that if the demands were not accepted at Antarwali Sarati, the protest would be taken to Mumbai. "We will go to Varsha Bungalow or Azad Maidan," he said, adding, "Mumbai residents should tolerate us. We are also your people."

Among the activist's fresh demands was the abolition of caste scrutiny committees in the State. "Caste scrutiny committees do not exist in other States. Why has this mechanism been kept only in Maharashtra? This information was given to me by Revenue Minister Radhakrishna Vikhe-Patil himself," he said, suggesting that the process instead be simplified at the tehsildar level.

Meanwhile, Jalna district police served Mr. Jarange-Patil a notice to ensure law and order during the protest.



Assam Congress workers shouting slogans during a protest march in Guwahati on Saturday. PTI

Assam Cong. holds protests over ESZ around Kaziranga

Press Trust of India
GUWAHATI

The Assam Congress on Saturday organised 'padayatras' across the State to protest the proposed reduction of the Eco-Sensitive Zone (ESZ) around Kaziranga National Park.

Congress leaders and workers participated in protests in several districts, including Sonitpur, Lakhimpur, Hailakandi, Karimganj, Tinsukia, Karbi Anglong and Golaghat.

The protesters marched through the streets of district headquarters, raised slogans against the government and demanded withdrawal of the proposal to reduce the ESZ.

In Guwahati, Leader of Opposition in the Assembly Wazed Ali Choudhury,

former MP Ripun Bora, State women's wing president Mira Borthakur and other party leaders took part in the protest.

Police prevented the protesters from leaving the Congress office in the Dispur area, following which party workers attempted to breach the barricades and march onto the streets.

Mr. Choudhury said the protests would continue till the government reverses its decision. "We will not allow the BJP-led government to damage Kaziranga National Park, which is our pride," he said.

Mr. Bora and Ms. Borthakur said the Congress would take up the issue across the State and create awareness among people.

Mumbai Weather	max	min
Mumbai Airport	32	27
Pune	29	22
Mumbai City	32	27

Mumbai Today
32°C The weather will be little warm. Spell of light rain and thundershower to occur. Night will be comfortable.

Mumbai Tomorrow
32°C The weather to remain little warm. Night will be comfortable. Spell of light rain and thundershower may occur.

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THE HINDU

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THE HINDU

Surcharge:
Ahmedabad – Rs. 5.00

Timings		
MUMBAI		
SUNDAY, AUG. 30		
RISE 06:23	SET 18:55	
RISE 20:16	SET 08:04	
MONDAY, AUG. 31		
RISE 06:23	SET 18:54	
RISE 20:53	SET 08:58	
TUESDAY, SEP. 01		
RISE 06:24	SET 18:53	
RISE 21:34	SET 09:55	

WESTERN RAILWAY

E-AUCTION FOR THE CONTRACT OF PAY AND USE NORMAL TOILET BLOCKS

e-Auction for the contract for operation and maintenance of Normal Pay and use toilet blocks over Mumbai Division has been invited. The catalogue has already been published on IREPS website, the details are furnished as under:

Type of Contract: Normal Contract	Contract Period: 3 Years	Category: Pay and Use Toilet blocks
Auction catalogue No.	Station and Location	Date of E Auction
MMCT-PnUT-26-28	Toilet blocks at Borivali, Dahisar, Mira Road, Bhayander, Naigaon.	03.09.2026
MMCT-PnUT-26-28	Toilet blocks at Dadar, Matunga Road, Mahim.	
MMCT-PnUT-26-29	Seven Toilet blocks at Udhna Station.	04.09.2026

For all of above, time of e-Auction is 15:00 hrs.

NOTE: Prospective bidders are requested to visit e-Auction leasing module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The lot wise details are available there in under the mentioned catalogue. Initial cooling off period is 30 minutes. Successive Lot closing interval is 10 Minutes. Lot wise closing times can be viewed in e-Auction module of IREPS.

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OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

OBITUARY

V. RAMASWAMI
Formerly of India Meteorological Department
Passed away on 29th August 2026 at 4pm
Residence:
Flat 1D Fairwinds Apartment
51/19 Beach Road,
Kalakshetra Colony, Besant Nagar
Chennai - 600090
Last rites on 30th August 2026 at 3pm at Besant Nagar Crematorium
Shoba, Chitra, Latha and Family Members
Ph: 9840022323, 7397435259, 9594346140

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Email: shareddept_gc@jkbmail.com
CIN: L65110JK1938SGC000048

NOTICE OF 88TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, E-VOTING PROCEDURE AND CUT OFF DATE

Notice is hereby given that the 88th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Shareholders of the Jammu and Kashmir Bank Limited ("Bank"), will be held on **Tuesday, September 22, 2026 at 1100 hours at Sher-i-Kashmir International Conference Centre, Srinagar J&K** to transact the business as set out in the Notice of Annual General Meeting.

The Bank has sent Notice of the 88th AGM along with the Integrated Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 on Saturday, August 29, 2026 through electronic mode to Members whose email addresses are registered with the Bank/Registrar to an Issue & Share Transfer Agent/Depository Participants. A letter providing Direct Web Link, QR Code and Navigation Path where Notice of 88th Annual General Meeting and Integrated Annual Report for Financial Year 2025-2026 can be assessed has been dispatched to those Members whose email addresses are not registered.

The Notice of the AGM and Integrated Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 is available on the Bank's website at <https://jkb.bank.in/Investor/financial-information/annual-reports>, on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. The BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com, National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com and on the website of the M/s Bigshare Services Private Limited at www.bigshareonline.com

In compliance with Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 as amended from time to time, Regulation 44 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 and Secretarial Standards on General Meetings issued by the Institute of Company Secretaries of India (ICSI), Bank is pleased to provide e-voting facility through M/s Bigshare Services Private Limited for all shareholders of the Bank to enable them to cast their votes electronically on the items mentioned in the Notice of the 88 th Annual General Meeting of the Bank.	
The remote e-voting facility shall be available during the following period:	
E-Voting Event ID	1352
Cut-off date for determining Members entitled to vote	Tuesday, September 15, 2026
Commencement of remote e-voting period	Saturday, September 19, 2026 from 0900 Hours
End of remote e-voting period	Monday, September 21, 2026 upto 1700 Hours

Members holding shares of the Bank as on Cut-Off Date shall be entitled to vote during remote e-voting or voting at the AGM. Members can select Event ID: 1352 to cast their vote electronically. The remote e-voting module will be disabled by M/s Bigshare Services Private Limited after the end of remote e-voting. The facility for voting shall also be provided at the AGM. A Member can opt for only single mode of voting i.e. through remote e-voting or voting at the AGM. If a Member casts vote(s) by both modes, then voting done through remote e-voting shall prevail and vote(s) cast at the Meeting shall be treated as "INVALID". However, Members who have voted through remote e-voting shall be eligible to attend the AGM. Details of the process/method of casting votes by Members is included in the AGM Notice. Any person who acquires shares of the Bank and becomes a Member of the Bank after dispatch of the notice and holding shares as on cut-off date, may obtain the Login ID and Password by sending a request at ivote@bigshareonline.com

The voting rights of Members shall be in proportion to the equity shares held by them in the Paid-up Equity Share Capital of the Bank as on **Tuesday, September 15, 2026** being the "Cut-Off Date" for this purpose. A person whose name is recorded in the Register of Members or in the Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories as on the Cut-Off Date shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting as well as voting at the AGM.

Members who are holding shares in physical form or who have not registered their email addresses are requested to refer to the Notice of the AGM for the process to be adopted for obtaining the User ID and Password for casting the vote through remote e-voting. In case of any difficulty in casting vote through remote e-voting, Members may contact:

Mr. Prashant Gaonkar
Designation: Manager
M/s Bigshare Services Private Limited
Address: S6-2, 6th Floor, Pinnacle Business Park, Mahakali Cave Road, Next to Ahura Centre, Shanti Nagar, Andheri East, Mumbai, Maharashtra-400093
Telephone: 7506071172, 022-62638200
email: evcservices@bigshareonline.com
Website: www.bigshareonline.com

In case of any queries regarding e-Voting, you may refer the User Manuals and i-Vote e-Voting module available at <https://ivote.bigshareonline.com> under download section or you can email us to ivote@bigshareonline.com or call us at: 022-62638338. You may also send an e-mail to the Bank at: shareddept_gc@jkbmail.com.

We look forward for your participation at the 88th Annual General Meeting of the Bank.
Place: Srinagar
Date: 29th August, 2026

By order of the Board of Directors
Mohammad Shafi Mir
(Company Secretary)

SOUTH COAST RAILWAY
BANGALURU
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Tender Notice No.VSKP-TRS-10-2026-27

For and on behalf of the President of India, the undersigned invites E-Tender for the following works.

Name of work with its location: Certification of Energy Management System (EnMS) ISO: 50001: 2018 at Electric Loco Shed-Visakhapatnam for a period of three years. **Value of Tender (₹):** 48,982/- **Earnest Money to be deposited (₹):** 1000/- **Cost of Tender Form (₹):** 1,180/- **Address of the office:** Sr. Divl. Electrical Engineer (TRS), Electric Loco Shed, South Coast Railway, NAD Post, Visakhapatnam-530009 **Completion period of the work:** 3 years (36 months) **Bidding system:** Two packet system (e-tendering) **Tender closing date and time:** 18.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs **Website particulars:** <http://www.ireps.gov.in>

Sr.Divisional Electrical Engineer, SCoR-A267 (TRS), Visakhapatnam

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at <https://www.ireps.gov.in> or www.scor.indianrailways.gov.in

SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
BANGALURU
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Details of the Tender Notices of S.C Railway can be seen on our website: www.scor.indianrailways.gov.in

No.NW/148/WIII/Tender notice/2026-27 Date: 27.08.2026

For and on Behalf of President of India, The undersigned invite E-tenders for the following works.

S.No.: 01 Tender No. : T-202627-2-043 Authority: Co-ord Description of the work: Zone Works-Annual Section Contracts of Nanded Division for the year 2026-27:- Zonal Works for Malsailu to Akot (including service Building of SC Railway at Akola and including Akot). **Tender value in (₹):** 19896998.97 **Earnest money in (₹):** 397900.00 **Cost of tender form in (₹):** 0 **Completion period:** Nine Months

S.No.: 02 Tender No. : T-202627-3-043 Authority: Co-ord Description of the work: Zone Works-Annual Section Contracts of Nanded Division for the year 2026-27:- Zonal Works for ADE/PAU Section, service building and colonies. **Tender value in (₹):** 50478999.82 **Earnest money in (₹):** 1009600.00 **Cost of tender form in (₹):** 0 **Completion period:** Nine Months

SL No.: 01 Tender No.: T-202627-2-042, T-202627-3-043 Similar nature of work (for costing above 50 lakhs): Any Civil Engineering Work/Zonal maintenance works.

All above tenders will be closed 18.09.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.

For bid document and other details, login to <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. Any corrigenda will be issued online only

Sr.DEN/Co-ord/Nanded

TENDER NOTICE No: 23/2026 Dt.28.08.2026.

SUPPLY OF STORES ITEMS e-Procurement Tender Notice

The Following Tenders Have Been Floated Online. Tenders Are Requested To Visit The Website www.ireps.gov.in And Submit Their Offers Online. The Tender Description, Qty, EMD, SD May Be Seen In Website. Offers Submitted Manually Will Not Be Accepted. Offers By Post Will Not Be Entertained. Tender Closing Time is 14.30 Hrs Of The Due Date Of The Tender. "For All Indigenous Offers, EMD Will Be Accepted Only Via Online System As Available On www.ireps.gov.in."

Tender No.	Brief Description
LT256166A	Design, Supply, installation & commissioning of Hydraulic jacks provided with control stand & Power pack mounted on 04-wheeler Battery operated platform truck of 03T Capacity
LT265850	Supply and installation of Automatic fire alarm and fire aspiration system comply with RDSO Specification No. RDSO/SPN/217/2025, Version 3.1 or the latest applicable version at 50 stations/ locations over SC Division
46267002	107 SQMM Silver bearing Grooved copper contact wire
29265012	Coupling Socket Assembly with Locking Arrangement
82262704	Coronary Intravascular Lithotripsy Catheter, 80 PLS Sizes: 2.50, 2.75, 3.00, 3.25, 3.50, 3.75 and 4.00mm
43261072A	Disconnecting and Earthing Device, 8 pole, 2Way
56261004	PVC Insulated, armored signaling cable (copper conductor) sixize 2 core x 2.5 sq.mm
91261125	Aluminium Chequered Sheet 2.03x813x2960 mm.

Note:-Due dates of Tender Opening: SL.No.01 on dt.10.09.2026, SL.No.02 & 03 on dt.15.09.2026 SL.No.04 on dt.17.09.2026 SL.No.05 on dt. 18.09.2026 SL.No.06 & 07 on dt 21.09.2026. SL.No.08 on dt.26.10.2026.

Beside Above Mentioned Tenders There Are Other Tenders Having **Value Above Rs.50 Lakhs.**

For Details, Please Visit Railway Website Above.

Principal Chief Materials A711 Manager/Secunderabad

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at <https://www.ireps.gov.in> or www.scor.indianrailways.gov.in

INBRIEF



T.N. CM writes to Sitharaman over inland container depot

Tiruchi MP Durai Vaiko on Saturday said Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay had written a letter to Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman stating that the State government would soon undertake a detailed study to establish a multi-modal logistics hub, or inland container depot, in Tiruchi. The study will be carried out by the Tamil Nadu Industrial Development Corporation. The proposed facility will include container handling, warehousing, cold-chain facilities, cargo consolidation and customs clearance. Mr. Vaiko said the project would benefit regional trade and industry.

Punjab orders disciplinary action over strike absence

The Punjab government has directed departments to issue show-cause notices to employees who were “unauthorised absent” during the August 27 State-wide strike and initiate disciplinary action under service rules. Over three lakh employees took mass casual leave, affecting public services, while 3.50 lakh pensioners supported the protest. A scheduled meeting with Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann was cancelled after he said talks would be held only after the strike was withdrawn. Employees are demanding release of 18% dearness allowance, implementation of the Old Pension Scheme and regularisation of contractual staff.

Govt.: 37 Maharashtra tourists return from flood-hit Nepal, 60 remain untraceable

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Thirty-seven tourists from Maharashtra, who were stranded in the Nepal-Tibet region following the flash floods earlier this week, returned to Mumbai on Saturday evening, while 60 others from the State remained untraceable, stated the State government. The returnees included pilgrims who had underta-

106 tourists from Nagpur are expected to reach the city early on Sunday

ken the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra and were stranded in Saga in Tibet. One of them said the group had reached Saga on August 26, when they learnt of the devastation caused by the floods. Meanwhile, 106 tourists

Will send team to Nepal if MEA gives permission, says West Bengal CM

Delegation to include a Minister, an MLA and an IG-rank police officer, says Suvendu Adhikari; govt. manages to contact two of 39 people from the State missing after the Nepal flash floods

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari has said that the State government would send a team to Nepal to assist in rescue and relief operations if it received permission from the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

“I have asked the Chief Secretary to seek permission from the MEA to send our delegation to Nepal, which will include one Minister, one MLA, one IG-rank police officer, and a senior IAS officer of Secretary or Joint Secretary level. Once we get permission, we will move them to Kathmandu,” Mr. Adhikari said late on Friday night. Citing official records, he said of the 39 people from West Bengal reported missing in Nepal, the State government has managed to contact two and is arranging for their early return. They are Anukul Poddar and his wife, whose name



Social activists in Kolkata hold a prayer vigil on Saturday for the victims of the flash floods in Nepal.

has not been published yet. Both are aged above 60 and are from Basirhat. The remaining 37 are still untraced. “Many families have heard that some people have been rescued on the Tibet side. We have assured the families that we are trying to gather a list of those names,” he said.

CM's video call

On Friday night, the Chief Minister also spoke with

the families of the missing persons over a video call and assured them of all possible help in rescuing their loved ones. The video call, held from Bhawani Bhawan, the State police headquarters, was also attended by several senior police officials.

During the virtual meeting, the families raised concerns about the rescue and relief operations and sought information on

ways to track updates on their relatives.

Among the 37 people still missing from West Bengal, 32 had embarked on the Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra with Kolkata-based travel agency Cholo Jai. Of them, 30 were tourists, including at least 21 senior citizens, while two were tour operators.

One of those reported missing is Sharmistha Bhowmik Roy, daughter-in-law of former Union Minister Mukul Roy. Her husband, Subhrangshu Roy, a former MLA and Mukul Roy's son, told mediapersons that the families of those missing have now become like one family as they wait for their loved ones to return home.

Meanwhile, a delegation of senior Trinamool Congress leaders also met Mr. Subhrangshu Roy on Saturday.

His father, one of the founding members of the party, passed away a few months ago.

Six of 16 from Assam reported missing in Nepal flood safe: govt.

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) on Saturday said six of the 16 people from the State reported missing after the devastating flash flood in Nepal are safe.

Among the 10 still missing are a retired Gauhati University professor, her husband and a doctor at the Nalbari Medical College and Hospital in western Assam. “Family members have confirmed that Sonesar Narzary from Daidak village in Karbi Anglong district, Pankaj Barman and Samar Bezbaruah of Nalbari district's Arora village, and Shiva Marak, Sarbison Marak and Elipson Sangma of West Karbi Anglong's Satgaon area are safe,” an ASDMA spokesperson said.

‘Efforts ongoing’

On Friday, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the State government had identified 12 people from Assam who remained untraced after the tragedy struck Rasuwagadhi in northern Nepal around 8.35 a.m. Indian Standard Time on August 26. The ASDMA revised the list to 10 on Saturday.

“Efforts are under way

Among the 10 still missing are a retired Gauhati University professor, her husband and a doctor, ASDMA said

to establish contact with the missing people and ensure their safe rescue,” Mr. Sarma said.

According to the list of missing people shared by the ASDMA, two – Rhituopurno Brahma and Montri Basumatary – are from Daidak village in Karbi Anglong district.

Rahul Daimary from Jai-pukhuri village in Golaghat district, Shatadal Nath from Doboka town in Hojai district, Arun Mahanta from Arora village, Birson Sangma from the Satgaon area and Tirtha Chaliha, a doctor from Ghograpar in Nalbari district, are also on the list.

The remaining three are from Guwahati. They are Pankaj Naug from the Rukminigaon locality and Dipali Sarkar and her husband, Manash Kumar Ghosh, from the Lankeshwar area of the State capital. Ms. Sarkar and her husband were part of a 32-member group that was travelling to Kailash-Mansarovar in Tibet.

Day after skipping meet, Punjab Cong. chief joins issue with MP over remarks

Press Trust of India
CHANDIGARH

A day after Congress MP Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa referred to “compromised leaders” and “sleepers” in the party, Punjab Congress president Amrinder Singh Raja Warring on Saturday said he would ask the senior leader whom he was referring to.

“Randhawa saab is our



Amrinder Singh Raja Warring

senior leader... When we shared the stage, he spoke about compromised leaders and sleeper cells many times,” Mr. Warring said.

He agreed that “sleeper cells” existed in all parties.

“[Ravneet Singh] Bittu used to meet Union Home Minister Amit Shah and later, he left [the Congress and joined the BJP],” he said.

Mr. Warring said he would ask Mr. Randhawa whether he was referring to leaders meeting Mr. Shah or Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann.

“I will ask Randhawa

saab and make it clear that who are compromised and (working as) sleeper cells,” he said.

At the Congress's Rakhar Punia conference on Friday, Mr. Randhawa said the party needed “jujharu” (belligerent) leaders, “not those who are compromised”. Mr. Warring skipped the event amid continuing factionalism in the State unit ahead of the 2027 Assembly election.

SPOTLIGHT

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

It was a few minutes after 2 a.m. on a Wednesday, when Izaj Ahmed, 30, woke up to a pungent smell in his cramped hotel room. Thick smoke was billowing through the thin gap of the plywood door of his room at Hotel Shikha Inn at 15B Mirza Ghalib Street, in the heart of Kolkata.

“When I opened the door of my room to look outside, it was completely filled with smoke,” Ahmed said. He tried to take the staircase, but found that the narrow iron stairs had turned red-hot. Wasting no time, he jumped from the balcony of the third floor and landed on the asbestos roof of a shop. He remained stuck there until the fire brigade rescued him. Ahmed was one of around 60 people rescued on August 19.

The fire was brought under control in less than two hours, but by then it had claimed nine lives. Those who died could not find their way out of Florence Mansion, the five-storeyed building that houses eight hotels, seven offices, two residential apartments, and two shops.

When he checked into the hotel, Ahmed, a resident of Birbhum's Rampurhat, a regular in Kolkata, didn't give it a second

thought. “I have stayed in different hotels in this area before. Hotels are affordable here and the area is easily accessible in the city. But a fire was something I could never imagine,” Ahmed said.

The headquarters of Kolkata Municipal Corporation on S.N. Banerjee Road are less than 500 metres from Florence Mansion. The fire brigade headquarters at 13D, Mirza Ghalib Street are a few doors away. Yet the investigation so far has revealed glaring gaps in the fire audit.

Forty-eight hours before, there had been another fire at Bideshini Hotel in the temple town of Tarapith, about 224 kilometres from Kolkata. Nine persons died. Since 2025, there have been five major fires across West Bengal, killing 65 people.

Dead and survived

When Florence Mansion was constructed, it was a residential complex, mostly housing Kolkata's Sindhi community. Many sold their apartments as the locality turned from a residential area into a commercial centre.

The ground floor of the building reveals tangled wires and exposed electricity meters and MCB boxes. Next to the meter boxes is a spiral iron staircase leading to the dense, dark floors where sunlight struggles to reach even in the morning. A musty smell hangs over the damp

Turned into a tinderbox

In the span of a week 18 people lost their lives in two hotel fires in West Bengal, one in Kolkata, another in Tarapith. The fires exposed the gaps in the State's firefighting infrastructure, a lack of regulation, perpetuation of corruption, and society's divide between the haves and have-nots



People gather on Mirza Ghalib Street, Kolkata, after a fire broke out on the second floor of Florence Mansion, killing nine persons in Hotel Shikha Inn, including a four-year-old child.

interiors. Now, the building has been sealed.

Many of the survivors complained that no fire alarm was sounded when the fire broke out. When the residents were screaming for help, neither could they find fire extinguishers, nor did any staff member show up. There was also no emergency exit, and the main gate was locked, trapping those inside.

A former staff member of the hotel, Muhammed Jamal, who now works at a different hotel in the same area, said that fire extinguishers are never in

stalled in hotels in the area, where the room rents are about ₹1,500.

Mohammed Mushfiqur Rehman, who came to Kolkata from Dhaka, said for people who arrive from Bangladesh, there isn't much time to think about safety. “There are various agents who approach us the moment we arrive. They start dragging our luggage to take us to some hotel which has a reasonable rate,” Rehman said. He added that since many people from Bangladesh come to Kolkata, they get recommendations for ho-

tels in this area from neighbours or relatives.

Standing outside the hotel almost six hours after the fire, he said that he had met a family the previous evening. All had died in the fire.

Rehman was referring to the death of four family members of a Bangladeshi journalist Debashish Dutta, 39. Dutta, his wife Afsana Shimmim, 27, their two-year-old son Shranashish Dutta, and Debashish's father-in-law Akram Ali, 74, died in the fire at Shikha Inn.

Of the nine who died,

seven were Bangladeshi nationals; the other two were residents of Bihar and West Bengal.

Investigations

The preliminary investigation has revealed that the fire broke out due to a short circuit on the second floor of the hotel, most likely from an air conditioner. Those who died were staying on the second floor and could not use the staircase to escape.

Kolkata police has set up a five-member special investigation team headed by the Deputy Commissioner of the Detective Department to probe the incident. The FIR has been filed under several sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, including culpable homicide not amounting to murder and negligence, and under sections of the West Bengal Fire Services Act.

On August 20, the police arrested the leaseholder of the hotel, Abu Zafar, and the manager of Jaapon Hotel located inside Florence Mansion. Two days later, the owner of Shikha Inn, Bireswar Mitra, was arrested in Behala, said Anuel Aggarwal, Additional Commissioner of Kolkata Police (Crime). During questioning, the owner confessed that he had paid ₹1 lakh to ₹1.5 lakh to local touts and syndicates to secure the licence to run the hotel.

“The hotel had nine rooms. He used to charge ₹1,300 to ₹1,500 per day

per room. However, the rooms were converted from a residential flat using flammable plywood partitions and false ceilings. He also never held a valid fire NOC (No Objection Certificate) for the property,” said a police source. Ten days later, at least 52 hotels have been shut down by the Kolkata Municipal Corporation and the Fire Department in the area for allegedly failing to meet fire safety norms. Fearing inspections, many hotels closed their doors temporarily, while over 200 show-cause notices have also been issued to various hotels.

Tarapith hotel fire

About 4.30 a.m. on August 17, a fire broke out on the ground floor of Hotel Bideshini in Tarapith when most of the guests were asleep. Investigations have revealed that there were two exits from the hotel, but many boarders of the hotel could not find the back door. The hotel's power supply had been cut off by the fire, and in the darkness, it was difficult for them to find their way. Out of the nine who died, four were from West Bengal and five from Garo Hills, Meghalaya. Thirty-four were rescued.

The hotel advertises itself as “located beside the Police Station in Tarapith”. Birbhum Superintendent of Police Vedit Raj Bhundesh said the fire might have been caused by

a short circuit on the ground floor and later spread across a few other floors.

The police arrested a father-son duo who were running the hotel. Up to 15 hotels were given closure notices in Tarapith.

A Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) report released in 2021 said West Bengal recorded 591 accidental fire incidents in 2019, resulting in 528 deaths and 12 injuries. The CAG report pointed out a 68% shortfall in fire stations and 74% of fire operator posts were vacant.

The economic burden

For the past several years, hotels, guest houses, and inns across the 1-km stretch around New Market have served thousands of Bangladeshi nationals who visit Kolkata for medical tourism and shopping.

Now, hotel owners fear an uncertain future. “We were told that since the building itself was in a high-risk zone, we would not be allowed to accept guests,” a hotel owner on Mirza Ghalib Street said.

Several hotel owners also alleged that the fire department had not renewed fire licences of several establishments in the area for the past two years. The owners are planning to meet Ministers in the West Bengal government and approach the Calcutta High Court for a reprieve.

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BEAUTIFUL VEGETARIAN 32, 163cm, thoughtful, accomplished, UK-based (can relocate). Seeks compatible groom. Caste no bar. Call/WA 93456 34365

34YRS BTECH (NIT) MBA IIT working in MNC Chennai 24 LPA Fair looking for suitable match CNB Ct:9940507235

PROPOSALS INVITED from affluent families for Pillai / Nair girl, 26 years, raised in UK & USA, very pretty and modern, law graduate, for her remarriage. Caste or language - No issues.Contact: +1 602 481 5783

MS-QC, AGE 31, working UK. Seeking Groom well-Educated & Job Age 35 preferable Abroad. Ct: 909296242.

DOCTOR

25YRS CSI-NADAR Fair MBBS- Ready to MEET- Upper-middle. Seeks a Groom, Doctor or No.1 Officer in Govt. Any Christian ok. Ct: 8610774168

HINDU, KERALA, Professional parents settled in UAE seek alliance for their daughter, 26 Years, MBBS presently doing MD in reputed college in India. Alliance invited from parents of doctors practicing/ studying in India or Abroad. Caste no bar. Email or Aspiev68@gmail.com

DOCTOR

FAIR, CULTURED, Good looking, Slim, Doctor girl, first marriage, 37/162, MD, Cardiac Anesthesiologist, Chennai based affluent Doctor family. Father Keralite Nair, Mother from TN. Looking for Doctor or Engineer groom from respectable family. Ct: 9840050381/ 9840985383

Affluent Hindu Nadar Family invites an Alliance for their daughter: 32 yrs, 5'4", Fair, Doctor, currently in USA (willing to relocate) Belongs to a prominent, wealthy background. Seeking a well educated Groom, settled in USA or India. Ct: +91 9791994449 vsajsr@gmail.com

IAS / ALLIED SERVICES

WANTED GROOM

Hindu Reddy fair girl, 30 years, Height 5'2" B tech from IIT, chennai, presently Undergoing training as indian forest officer (IFos). Preferred: IAS/IPS/IFos and other central govt Group A&B officers. preferably General & OBC category.

Contact what's App **9160666670**
Mail ID **y.ram.ssa@gmail.com**

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Hindu, tamil, gounder, 45 yrs, IPS, seeks Groom, Contact Phone 9578833026

MALAYALAM

MENON FAIR Girl 24yrs star Anisham with 1.75 dosham doing Phd Clinical Psych in Med College@ Chennai seeks well educated & placed testotoler groom with clean habits. Mom-School Principal, dad--MNC. Grand parents--Retd from Defence Ct: 9895794814

ALLIANCE INVITED for Hindu Nair bride, 29/162 cm, Ph.D (Physics) scholar, seeks suitable well educated working groom. Ph: 9446591044.

NRI

Affluent Hindu Nadar Family Invites an Alliance for their Daughter: 27Yrs, B.Tech, MS (USA), Working in USA. Belongs to Elite Business Family. Seeking a well Educated Hindu Nadar Groom in USA. Mobile: 96599-91119 / 98423-44133.

TAMIL

SINGAPORE TAMIL Muslim girl, aged 35yrs looking Engineering/ overseas studied lawyer etc. overseas working/experienced boy whatsapp details/photos to +6581399152/ 96592720042

MBBS 31 Christian DKV Govt MBBS PG Doctors Gp1/2 Officers preferred 7904678043

ROMAN CATHOLIC, Private, searching for a groom from 27-31 from any subcaste anywhere in India. 8138900487

CATHOLIC, DIVORCED, M.Sc, looking for a groom from 35-41 from any Christian from 2nd marriage profiles, 8137001255

PENTECOST, B.ARCH, Business, 10C PA, looking for a groom for our daughter from 23-28 in TN, Karnataka, Pondi. Ph: 8137003550

CSI, PhD, Seeking for a groom from 28-32 from equal caste in Tamilnadu, 8137001247

CHRISTIAN, DOCTOR, 39 Years Unmarried, Well Settled Family. Seeks Unmarried Doctor Groom. Ct: 755026805

TAMIL

PROTESTANT, MS, Private, looking for a groom from 28-33 from Rich/Affluent in USA or India who willing to relocate, 8137001247

ROMAN CATHOLIC, 32, Business, MBA, looking for any Christian, upper middle or rich groom profile in Pondicherry or Tamilnadu, Kerala, 8138900412

CSI, BDS, looking for a groom from UK and France from 27-36 doctor profile, 8137003516

CHRISTIAN NADAR 30 yrs, BBI Grade B officer seeks suitable groom. AIS / GOI / IT / Doctors / Business. Ct: 9444543920 / 9445366732

TAMIL MUSLIM Fair, 31/157, B.E., MBA, MNC Employee, Short Marriage - Khula Given, Issueless. Seeks Never-Married, Well-Settled Groom. WhatsApp: 637445811.

CATHOLIC, B.com, Chennai, 28, looking for a groom from 28-33 Rich/Affluent in same community. 8138900487

CSI, Rich/Affluent, Business, looking for a groom from CSI, Nadar from 25-30 from India, UK PR, Rich/Affluent, 8138009214

CHRISTIAN VANNIYAR BRIDE 31 / 159 cm / Deputy Commercial Tax Officer, B.Tech, 8 LPA, expecting Doctors, Bank Manager, Govt employee from any BC Christian. Ct: 63741 36192.

CHRISTIAN-RC SOZHIA Vellalar, DnB-Radiology, 28yr, Chennai. Seeks Professional Match, RC Groom 9840150090

BORN AGAIN Christian, 45yrs/152, MBBS, MD doctor, seeks christian groom, Chennai. CT - 9500188067

SC PR, Divorcee no issue, 32yrs, B.E CSC, fair, well settled in Madurai, seeks suitable groom from reputed family. 97901 27249, 75399 28516

NADAR 35/5'6" MBA working in Chennai Elite Family Seeks qualified Groom working in Cennai, only Hindu-. 9962991979

BRIDEGROOM WANTED For a well-to-do hindu family's bride aged 43, first marriage, degree-MSW, want from (FC, BC, MSC), working within India. Ct: 90803-59664.

GROOM WANTED Naidu,27yrs, Divorcee, MBBS, MS,Well Educated Family in Chennai Ph:6385293227

TAMIL

GROOM WANTED Rich Mudaliar.27yrs, MBBS, MS, Well Educated family in Chennai Ph:7200187009

GROOM WANTED Hindu Nadar 28yrs,BE,SWE,1.5L p/m, well educated family Ph:9841329471, 9380791999

✓ ALLIANCE INVITED for 26 year-old, Tamil, SC, well educated, postgraduate daughter, working with a leading corporate law firm dealing in Capital Markets, advising reputed companies and banks on IPOs and major financial transactions. Intelligent, family-oriented with a modern outlook and strong values. Seeking a well-educated, professionally accomplished groom, from a respectable family. Ph 944415358

MUDHALIYAR, MBA, Entrepreneur, Looking for a groom from 28-33 in same caste from Rich/Affluent family, 8138900412

MUDALIYAR, RICH/AFFLUENT, Divorced MA, Business, 48, looking for good looking profile from 48yrs, 8138900312

PILLAI, MD, 30, looking for a groom from 30-35 from TN and Karnataka.Highly educated.8137003516

SC, NRI, Nursing Professional, Looking for a groom from 29-34 in any caste, 8138009214

NAIDU 34/158CM Divorced short lived B.Tech French Professor, PR Canada applied Seeks Suitable Groom without Children Caste No Bar 9444255509

GROOM WANTED Naidu,30yrs,B Tech, Elite business family in Chennai Ph:9952619776

GROOM WANTED Hindu Nadar 24yrs,MA, well settled elite business family Ph: 9380791999,9841329471

Girl 35/5.4, Good Looking Business 1L Pm Seeks Well Settled Lonely Groom Aged 40+ Own Decision 79056603908

MUDALIAR- 22V,FAIR & Beautiful, MBA, Father Industrialist, Elite Family, Seeks Groom Business / Doctor - Ct: 8925019776

SC, NRI, Nursing, Govt, looking for any European countries or relocate profile groom from any caste or religion, 8137001255

TAMIL

WANTED BRIDE from NON-VADHoola Gothram family for Bright, Successful GROOM aged 30 Years working as LEGAL MANAGER in a Corporate Company of repute in MUMBAI. Only son and child of their parents. Reply with details to lalithakasiraman95@gmail.com

Vadakkalai Iyengar Boy, Punarpoosam Bharadwaja Gothram 1979/170 Never Married MS(IT), MNC Chennai, 32 LPA Alliance invited from Brahmin Brides or Any Pure Vegetarian is Fine. Contact with Biodata, Photo & Horoscope on WhatsApp: 7299704899 / 7395989198

Seeking BRIDE for Bridegroom
Hindu, Kulalar/Udayaar, 44 yrs, 170 cms, M.Tech, IT professional, Caste open for discussion. First Marriage Only
CT: 93842 76066

Tamil, Good Family 32Years, ME, MBA (SIOM), 30 LPA seeks suitable Bride, CNB. Contact: 9441677205.

IYER 31/170cm, B.Com(H), VP in PVT Ltd Co, Chennai, Teetotaler with Clean Habits, Parents Retd Govt., seeks Suitable Hindu Bride. Caste No Bar / Horoscope Not Particular. Ct: 98730 22289

KURUMBA GOUNDER Remarriage 32 /167 Bcom MBA Chennai Son 7 years Seeks Working Bride. Geetham 9884858014

TAMIL YADAVA Boy, M.B.A, 38, Aiyilam, TCS, Chennai. Seeks Yadava bride within TN.Sozhia Vellalar, Mudaliyar considerable. Horoscope not necessary. Speak through Tamil. W.app: 9965673354 / Ct:7373386474.

MUDALIAR 30/182 handsome BE, MS, SWE, TESLA USA,190000.USD.PA, Elite, 75 Cr, CNB. 9043991629, 9043987029

SAIVAPILLAI REMARRIAGE 49/175 M.Tech Pvt Company GM Son 18yrs Seeks Suitable Veg Bride. Geetham 9884858014

TELUGU

TELUGU VANNAR, 41, MBA, Kann, Ashtam, AGM in MNC, 33 Lac.PA, Any Telugu Caste No Bar. Ct: 9894777905

BRIDE WANTED Telugu chetty,34yrs, MBA, Elite business family in Chennai.Ph 6385293227

NAIDU 29/185 H-some B.Tech, MS, SWE, Twitter-X,USA,180000.USD.PA, Elite,80 Cr, CNB. 9043991629, 9043987029

URDU

Muslim Boy 29/167, IT Manager Chennai sal. 32 LPA, Educated Girl Contact: 9444376676

MUSLIM SYED, 29 yrs, 168 cm, handsome Doctor, MBBS, MD, DM, ALIMs, Chennai, seeks a beautiful, well-educated bride, preferably MD/MS Doctor. Contact: 99528 28485

Muslim Boy 1994 Born / 180 cms / MBBS / MS / Surgeon / Residing in UK / Bangalore Family (9164400029)

Sunni Muslim Boy, 36 Yrs, 178 cms, Divorced, M.Tech, Working Dubai, Bangalore Family (080-69144026)

Sunni Muslim boy, 1995-born, M.Tech, Senior Software Engineer 60 LPA, Bangalore family (080-69141325)

TAMIL

SAIVA VELLALAR, MD, looking for a Vegetarian profile from Masters in any caste, 8138900553

23yrs, MSC, upper middle class, seeking for a groom from 23-28 in pillai and mudaliar from tamilnadu, 8138900412

27, DKV, Government, M.Pharm, looking for a groom from same caste in upper/rich family from govt or doctor profession, 8138900312

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NADAR, Bsc, Private, looking for groom from Equal caste with Raku/Ketu, Vegetarian, 8137 003550

HINDU AGAMUDAYAR DOB 3/4/1994 Pooradam, Dhanasu, B.Tech, M.S.(USA) now India willing to relocate seeks Grooms qualified with good family Ct: 94423 99555, 94441 23278

SC AD 33 MCA Unmarried Seeking Suitable Groom Ph: 8610410886 Unmarried Certificate must. Brokers Excuse

SC AD 29/161 M.E. Ph.D (A.U-Guindy) barani Mesham Sewai Dosham seeks well educated groom with strong family values. Contact: 9597340840 / 8056494772

MUDALIAR 25/162, Fair, BE, MS, SWE, CISCO USA, 90000.USD.PA, Elite, 30 Cr, CNB. 9043991629, 9043987029

GROOM WANTED Mudaliar.31yrs,BE, Rich and Affluent business family in Chennai.Ph: 9952619776

GROOM WANTED Naidu,31yrs, MBBS, MD, Well Educated Family background.Ph: 6385293227

MUDALIAR 25, BE, MS, 163cm Good Looking Well settled Family Seeks Groom CNB.Ct: 8778514465 / 7200866346

SC AD 25/B.E.,PG in Dip.Mgmt.HR Professional/Recruitment Co.Js Lakhs p.m. seeks Bridegroom. Ph:7397674481

28YR GYNAECOLOGIST Asst.Prof Government, Chennai seek Vegetarian Doctor/professional groom Ct: 8778447714

DKV/SC MAY 94/32, 167cm Fair BE Parents Hindu / CSI, Seeks Groom Dr./Er. / Abroad / Govt. Ct: 8056143638

BRAHMIN, 25, Iyengar, MBBS, seeking for a brahmin groom from 25-32, well - educated and well settled including NRI, 8137003550

BRAHMIN-IYER, Surgeon, Looking for a groom from 28-32 in same community from Doctor, CA, Civil service in Mumbai, bangalore, Palakkad, Dubai, 8137003516

BRIDES & GROOMS WANTED

ENGLISH

HINDU NADAR 26/163cm MBBS MS V Fair Girl Dr Family Own Hospital 3 Chennai Younger Brother 24/180cm MS First Year. Ct: 7550113468

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THE HINDU

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TAMIL

CHETTIAR / MUDALIYAR / PILLAI
BRIDEGROOM WANTED
1984 Born, fair and good looking Doctor seeks suitable groom with high moral values and clean habits.
Poosam / Kadaga Rasi
Contact :
98430 96097

BRIDEGROOM WANTED

Well-settled Hindu Nadar family seeks suitable alliance for their daughter, 24/162cm, fair-complexioned, currently pursuing Doctor of Veterinary Medicine (DVM) at an Ivy League University in the USA.

Seeking a well-educated, professionally established groom, preferably 25 -27 years, currently settled in the USA or willing to relocate.

Contact:
spurspark777@gmail.com
Ph: 999 43 43 897

BRIDEGROOM WANTED

Tamil Speaking Cosmopolitan Girl 1993 born M.Tech in Embedded Systems Working in Bangalore Looking for a Doctor or Engineer Never Married Boy Settled in Bangalore.

CALL 96115 52776

TAMIL MUSLIM 24 Years MBA Seeks Groom working in UAE, USA, India. For Details Contact: 98431 95231.

Tamil, Good Family 29Yrs, B.Tech, MBA (BIM), 26 LPA, seeks suitable Groom, CNB. Contact: 9441677205.

Tamil, Good Family, 26Yrs, B.Sc(OU), UMC, Fair Girl seeks suitable Groom, CNB. Contact: 9441677205.

VANIYAR Chettiar, 29 yrs beautiful, C.A.working in MNC Bangalore. We prefer Hindu Groom with C.A/Financial Executive/M.E.M.Tech only working in Bangalore or Chennai Tamil speaking Non-Vegetarian from Chettiar Mudaliar and Pillai.Please send horoscope & other details only to WhatsApp: 8939589600

Sunni Muslim Girl, 22 Years, Beautiful, From a Respected & Educated Family (080-69144019)

Sunni muslim parents seek suitable match for their daughter 30/5'3" LL.M. NLU, Hyderabad, NET qualified, Advocate, working with reputed Law firm, earning 20 lacs. Mobile 9762242301

BRIDES WANTED

COSMOPOLITAN

37YRS, B.TECH mgr govt Bank salary 1.5 LPM owning properties in Ch. Seeking alliances CNB. 9940507235

DM DOCTOR (Hindu,Tamil, 34yrs, 185cm V.fair Hashtam) seeks a tall slim, fair



MDMA packets seized by the police in Keralam.

MDMA worth ₹10 cr. seized in Keralam; three arrested

The Hindu Bureau
MALAPPURAM

A police squad from Malappuram in Keralam seized 12.8 kg of MDMA valued at more than ₹10 crore from a car in Coimbatore. Three persons from Malappuram and Wayanad were arrested.

The arrested were Jabir Ali, 32, from Panthallur near Manjeri; Mohammed Salih, 34, from Meppadi in Wayanad; and Shaim Akbar, 21, from Anakkayam near Manjeri.

The arrests were made by a special investigation team led by district police chief Chaitra Teresa John. Manjeri Inspector T.G. Di-leep and the District Anti-Narcotics Special Action Force (DANSAF) squad were part of the team.

The police said the MDMA was being transported for distribution in Keralam and Tamil Nadu. The drugs were concealed in the door panels of an In-nova car.

The MDMA was packed in quantities ranging from 100 to 500 g for delivery at multiple locations in Keralam, the police said.

Revanth seeks 4 more weeks for revision of electoral rolls

Nearly one-third of Telangana electorate have to prove their eligibility, says Chief Minister in letter to CEC Gyanesh Kumar; govt. apprehensive that a large number of voters will be left out of the list

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy on Saturday urged the Election Commission of India to extend the claims and objections period for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the State by four weeks, citing concerns over the large number of voters flagged for verification and the possibility of eligible electors being left out.

In a letter to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, Mr. Reddy said the revision had reached a critical stage, with nearly one-third of the State's electorate potentially required to estab-



In his letter to the CEC, Revanth Reddy proposed many safeguards, including public reading of draft electoral rolls. SIDDHANT THAKUR

lish their eligibility afresh.

According to the letter, against the State's electoral roll of 3.38 crore electors as of June 10, around 73.39 lakh entries have been placed under the cate-

ries of Absent, Shifted, Dead and Duplicate (ASDD). Of the 2.65 crore enumeration forms digitised so far, 60.5 lakh have been flagged for anomalies and another 32.36 lakh for

lack of a link to the previous electoral roll. The two categories are distinct, taking the total number of electors requiring notice to 92.86 lakh, the letter said.

ASDD classification

Mr. Reddy expressed concern over the ASDD classification, noting that 45.19 lakh, or nearly 62% of the 73.39 lakh ASDD entries, had been classified as 'permanently shifted'.

Besides seeking a four-week extension of the claims and objections period, currently scheduled from August 17 to September 16, with final publication on October 19, the Chief Minister proposed several safeguards, including public reading of draft electoral rolls.

Cong. expels leader for blocking Satheesan's motorcade

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Chenthi Anil, the District Congress Committee (DCC) member who was arrested by the police on Saturday for stopping Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan's convoy, has been expelled from the party.

Thiruvananthapuram DCC president N. Sakthan expelled Mr. Anil from the primary membership of the party, even as the district-level leader was remanded in judicial custody for 14 days on Saturday. Mr. Sakthan told *The Hindu* that blocking the Chief Minister's vehicle cannot be justified under any circumstance.

Mr. Anil, along with a group of people, had allegedly blocked the convoy and misbehaved with Mr. Satheesan for declining to attend the Sree Narayana Guru Jayanti celebrations planned at Chenthi here.

Following the incident on Friday evening, police had registered an FIR against Mr. Anil and had taken him into custody on Saturday.

Sources in the Chief Minister's office said Mr. Satheesan had been advised against attending the event based on intelligence inputs and that his office had informed the organisers a week ago that he would be unable to attend.

Speaking to reporters on Saturday, Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said the law will take its course.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday

TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.45 HRS)

Forecast for Sunday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha, Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh. Thunderstorm with lightning likely at isolated places over Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	7.5	35.3	25.8	Kurnool	—	34.4	25.7
Ahmedabad	—	33.2	26.0	Lucknow	28	33.8	26.4
Aizawl	34	33.0	22.5	Madurai	—	40.0	26.1
Bengaluru	—	29.3	20.1	Mangaluru	15	29.5	24.5
Bhopal	0.4	28.6	23.0	Mumbai	3.8	31.5	26.8
Bhubaneswar	—	31.7	26.6	Mysuru	4	31.2	19.2
Chandigarh	—	36.1	26.0	New Delhi	—	36.2	27.7
Chennai	0.8	38.0	27.6	Patna	4.8	34.2	26.6
Coimbatore	0.6	33.2	21.8	Port Blair	3	29.5	26.6
Dehradun	0.4	31.2	24.3	Prayagraj	61.2	30.2	26.8
Gangtok	0.1	22.6	19.1	Puducherry	—	36.0	25.0
Goa	0.6	30.6	25.8	Pune	1	29.2	22.0
Guwahati	2.4	35.5	27.3	Raipur	11	26.1	23.8
Hubballi	—	28.0	21.0	Ranchi	53	28.7	23.0
Hyderabad	—	30.2	23.9	Shillong	25	28.3	18.7
Imphal	—	30.7	22.9	Shimla	—	27.8	20.2
Jaipur	—	34.8	26.2	Srinagar	—	33.5	19.6
Kochi	1.4	30.8	25.2	Thiruvananthapuram	—	32.4	24.6
Kohima	—	25.4	18.8	Tiruchirappalli	—	38.3	27.6
Kolkata	1.1	33.7	27.8	Vijayawada	—	36.8	28.2
Kozhikode	26	32.4	24.8	Visakhapatnam	—	32.8	29.4

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	12	36	59	46	99	■	In observation made at 4.00 pm, Baraut, Uttar Pradesh recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 262
Bengaluru	19	17	38	101	130	■	indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Korba, Chhattisgarh recorded a healthy AQI score of 18
Chennai	5	14	53	46	59	■	
Delhi	34	24	37	373	430	■	
Hyderabad	12	12	30	42	68	■	
Kolkata	5	29	37	69	92	■	
Lucknow	11	18	93	34	39	■	
Mumbai	10	27	44	16	41	■	
Pune	17	13	71	24	79	■	
Visakhapatnam	20	68	19	55	112	■	

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

INBRIEF



Medical college in Karnataka to be named after Hegde

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Saturday announced that the proposed medical college in Uttara Kannada, the home district of former Chief Minister Ramakrishna Hegde, and a major road in the Shivaram Karanth Layout in Bengaluru, would be named after the late leader. On the occasion of Hegde's birth centenary celebrations, Mr. Shivakumar recalled his contribution to decentralisation and education in Karnataka. Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan termed Hegde a statesman and a nationalist.

Idukki policeman suspended for sharing 'anti-Muslim' post

Idukki District Police Chief A. Naseem suspended a police officer on Friday night for sharing an 'anti-Muslim' post on Facebook. The suspended official is a grade sub-inspector (SI). He had shared a viral video depicting the ruining of an *Athapookkalam* (flower carpet), along with comments allegedly targeting the Muslim community. Muslim Youth League filed a complaint with the police over this. Mr. Naseem, subsequently directed the Thodupuzha Deputy Superintendent of Police to conduct an inquiry. Based on the findings, the SI was suspended.

A.P. Police bust inter-State burglary gang; six arrested

The Andhra Pradesh Police on Saturday arrested six members of an inter-State gang allegedly involved in 13 theft cases, and recovered valuables worth around ₹60 lakh. Anantapur Superintendent of Police P. Jagadish said 393 grams of gold, 100 grams of silver and ₹1.49 lakh in cash were recovered from the accused. According to the police, the gang allegedly targeted victims by posing as passengers before stealing handbags from crowded areas. Some also operated by posing as scrap collectors, and break into locked houses in residential areas.

A grand finale



Bringing the curtains down on Onam celebrations, people dressed like big cats take to the streets of Thrissur, Keralam, during the city's famed *Pulikkali* performance, on Saturday. Amid cheering crowds, about 450 people took part in the annual spectacle. K.K. NAJEEB

Youth body prepares over 1 lakh bamboo seed balls, sets record

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The Confederation of Indian Industry's (CII) Young Indians (Yi) Chapter in Amravati set a new record in the Asia Book of Records for the maximum number of native bamboo seed balls prepared by a youth organisation, with 1,13,109 seed balls prepared in a single day at the P.B. Siddhartha College of Arts & Science here on Saturday.

The initiative was aimed at promoting climate action, afforestation, volunteerism and ecological responsibility, according to a press release.

The Yi Chapter in Andhra Pradesh capital Amara-vati said the initiative was

The initiative was aimed at promoting afforestation, climate action, volunteerism and ecological responsibility

part of its efforts to engage and empower young people to contribute meaningfully to nation-building. The seed ball preparation drive was undertaken as a tangible step towards environmental conservation and sustainable development.

The Chapter said it was encouraging young people to move beyond awareness and participate actively in initiatives aimed at protecting the environment.

Illegal trekking and 'hidden spot' tourism raise alarm in Karnataka's Western Ghats

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Residents and environmentalists across the Western Ghats, particularly in Kodagu and Chikkamagaluru districts of Karnataka have raised concerns over the growing trend of tour operators promoting hidden and remote natural spots for trekking and adventure activities.

Residents fear that the sudden influx of tourists in ecologically fragile areas could cause irreversible damage to forests, water sources, and wildlife habitats. They allege treks are being organised to these spots without permission from the Forest Department.

The increased footfall has resulted in tourists



Crowd puller: Social media is abuzz with videos of tourists flocking to see *Neelakurinji* in bloom across the Western Ghats. FILE PHOTO

leaving behind plastic waste and other garbage, they said.

Sensitive ecology

In Kodagu, the Forest Department recently intensified action against unauthorised commercial trekking in sensitive forest areas and warned travel agents against promoting illegal trekking routes.

AIMIM asks MLC Mirza Rahmat Baig to resign from party

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen expelled Member of Telangana Legislative Council (MLC) Mirza Rahmat Baig from the party on Friday night.

As per its announcement, Mr. Baig has been instructed to tender his resignation to the Chairman of the Legislative Council. While the reason for the decision was not stated, insiders said the MLC was found in a state of indiscipline, of which the party leadership took a very serious view.

On Saturday, Mr. Baig

removed pictures of AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi from his X account banner photo. He also deleted references to both the party and the Hyderabad parliamentarian from his bio. Earlier, he had approached the police alleging that certain persons were threatening to release deepfakes to tarnish his reputation. He maintained innocence and said that there was a conspiracy to cast aspersions on him.

The expulsion came soon after this.

The Hindu tried to reach Mr. Baig for comments. However, his phone remained out of reach.

al small waterfalls and other natural spots that are increasingly being accessed by tourists. Many of these places are located in or close to sensitive forest areas and are not equipped to handle large numbers of visitors.

In Chikkamagaluru also, environmentalists have urged the administration and the Forest Department to prohibit adventure activities in forest areas without permission.

Forest Minister Ramalinga Reddy said on Friday, "Forest areas cannot be opened up for commercial activities merely because some locations become popular on social media... Officials have been directed to identify such activities and take action against those violating the rules."

‘Not a good sign if a Bar Council loses respect’

India, China yet to announce meeting sites

PM in Uzbekistan for 2-day visit ahead of SCO summit

BJP worker in custody for copying SIR forms; 5 BLOs suspended

Kharge urges govt. to ensure safety of Indians in Nepal

Mobile phones, SIM cards, seized from terror convict's cell

AI can aid healthcare, doctors must lead decisions, say experts

Stakes high as India seeks to reconnect with Central Asia

INBRIEF



Suspected Pak. drone triggers search operation along LoC

A drone suspected to be from Pakistan was spotted hovering over forward areas along the Line of Control (LoC) in Jammu and Kashmir's Poonch district, prompting security forces to launch a search operation in the area early Saturday, officials said. The drone was spotted in Balakote in the Mendhar sector late Friday evening, and it moved towards the Mangalnar-Dabrote side near the border before returning to Pakistan, the officials said. They said Army troops guarding the LoC intensified surveillance and launched a search operation at first light to determine whether it had dropped or carried any suspicious material. PTI

UGC-NET results announced; over 4,000 qualify for JRF

The results of the UGC National Eligibility Test (NET) for 84 subjects have been announced, with more than 4,000 candidates qualifying for the Junior Research Fellowship, the National Testing Agency has said. 6.07 lakh candidates took the exam, out of which over 97,000 qualified for PhD admissions, a senior NTA official said on Friday. The examinations were conducted in June, with the NTA releasing the UGC-NET answer key on August 16. It also issued a special notice for re-examinations in Sociology, Commerce and English papers after an expert committee found factual, typographical, and language-related errors in the question papers. PTI

Bombay HC disposes PIL on language rule for drivers

The Bombay High Court on Saturday disposed of a public interest litigation (PIL) petition after the Maharashtra government informed the court that auto-rickshaw, taxi and cab drivers in the State would be given one year to acquire a working knowledge of Marathi. A division Bench of Acting Chief Justice Ravindra Ghuge and Justice Gautam Ankhad was hearing the PIL filed by four Uber drivers challenging the government's requirement that drivers possess a working knowledge of Marathi to obtain permits. The Bench took note of media reports that the State had agreed to give drivers one year to learn the language.

Court takes cognisance of NIA charges in Red Fort blast case

A special court on Saturday has taken cognisance of a chargesheet filed by NIA in connection with the explosion near Red Fort in New Delhi on November 10, 2025 which killed 14 people and injured dozens. According to the 7,500-page chargesheet, filed in May, the explosion was allegedly orchestrated by a terror module led by a group of doctors who had been searching for a suicide bomber for a year. Dr. Umar-un-Nabi, the prime accused, allegedly drove the explosives-laden vehicle that detonated near Red Fort. The NIA arrested 11 people accused of facilitating the attack by providing logistical support, sheltering suspects and attempting to destroy evidence.

SUDOKU

			1					7
			7		8	6		
7						3	9	
8		1			2			
	5	3	9		6	7	4	
			4			2		8
	3	6						5
		5	2		1			
9					4			

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

5	4	8	7	2	3	9	6	1
3	9	7	1	6	5	2	4	8
1	6	2	9	4	8	7	5	3
6	8	3	2	5	1	4	7	9
4	2	1	6	9	7	8	3	5
9	7	5	8	3	4	1	2	6
7	1	6	3	8	2	5	9	4
8	5	9	4	7	6	3	1	2
2	3	4	5	1	9	6	8	7

A quiet move that has kept Dehradun's vultures safe

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Poisoning, veterinary non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs), food scarcity, and habitat loss continue to remain survival challenges for vultures in India.

A decade-old study, published in the latest issue of the *Journal of Threatened Taxa*, suggests that relocating a livestock carcass dump 2.4 km away from high-tension power infrastructure near Uttarakhand's Dehradun may have saved these large scavengers from another existential threat – electrocution.

The authors of the study are Javed Anver, Yash Vardhan Singh Sengar, Bikash

Ghimire, Vonchano Ngulie, Hemam Rama Nanda, Tashi P. Dorji, Ankit Sharma, Akshay Jain, Sas Biswas, Arun Kumar, and M. Muzahed.

Vultures are among the most threatened birds globally, having undergone severe population declines across Asia and Africa due to multiple anthropogenic pressures. According to the study, electrocution from power infrastructure has been the most under-reported threat.

The study documented electrocution mortality of vultures in the Sudhauwala region of Dehradun, based on 34 surveys conducted between May 2011 and February 2014. The study recorded 743 individual vul-



Vultures are among the most threatened birds globally, having undergone severe population declines globally. KESHAV VINOD

tures belonging to five species.

“During the study period, 46 vulture carcasses attributable to electrocution were documented in proximity to high-tension

power transmission structures. The highest proportion of mortality relative to observations was recorded for the Himalayan griffon (*Gyps himalayensis*), followed by the Eurasian grif-

‘Irreverent Gen Z a sure sign of our democratic progress’

In a memorial lecture, former Chief Justice of Orissa HC says student protests give assurance that people will turn to the Constitution and safeguard it in order to preserve the country's future

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

As the coinage ‘dimagi Naxal’ continues to trigger political debate, former Chief Justice of Orissa High Court Justice S. Muralidhar has said it was reassuring to find that an irreverent young generation is neither swayed by rhetoric nor deterred by the “demonising” of the ‘dimagi Naxal’.

He said the very lack of deference among the Gen Z was a “sure sign of democratic progress”.

“The recent protests by our Gen Z assure us that democracy in India will not be allowed to die and that people will turn to the Constitution and safeguard it in order to preserve this country's future,” Justice Muralidhar said in his address at the 28th D.S. Borker Memorial Lecture on ‘My Vision of India 2047’ held



recently here.

“...The India of 2047 would be better served if the government of the day stops weaponising law to punish those who peacefully protest about the denial of basic rights and if it stops labelling them as sinister acts of conspiracy to destabilise the government,” Justice Muralidhar, currently practising as a senior advocate in the Su-

preme Court, said.

He said the judiciary of 2047 would be better served if “today's judges act swiftly on complaints of grave State excesses”. “The Supreme Court of 2047 will hopefully not wait for over four years to decide whether reducing a State to a Union Territory is constitutionally valid...,” Justice Muralidhar said.

The former High Court

‘FSSAI's proposed warning labels could let unhealthy foods escape scrutiny’

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has proposed red hexagonal warning labels on packaged foods high in sugar, salt, and saturated fat, but critical gaps in the framework could leave several unhealthy products with no warning, nutrition advocate Arun Gupta said. While the proposal marks a step forward after sustained intervention by the Supreme Court, its “two or more” nutrients threshold is a major loophole, Dr. Gupta, convener of Nutrition Advocacy in Public Interest (NAPI), told *The Hindu*.

The Supreme Court recently pushed the Centre and FSSAI to act swiftly on front-of-pack warning labels for unhealthy packaged foods. The FSSAI has now proposed red, hexagonal labels flagging products high in sugar, salt or fat to help consumers make informed choices.

Faulty framework

Under the proposal, a warning would be triggered only when a product is high in two or more nutrients of concern – added saturated fat, added sugar, and added salt. “A product



The top court recently pushed the Centre and the FSSAI to act swiftly on front-of-pack warning labels for packaged foods.

could be high in sugar but carry no warning if it is low in fat and salt. That defeats the purpose of a warning label,” Dr. Gupta said.

The rule, he said, should be simple: “High in sugar – warning; high in salt – warning; high in saturated fat – warning.” He also called for time-bound implementation, and said the framework should be aligned with the Indian Council of Medical Research-National Institute of Nutrition (ICMR-NIN) Dietary Guidelines, 2024, which provide thresholds for total sugar and total fat per 100 gm.

Dr. Gupta also questioned the proposed use of “added” nutrients and called for following a clear, scientifically robust definition of high fat, sugar and salt (HFSS) foods. “India already has an HFSS definition reflected in the 2022 draft notification and par-

liamentary discussions. We should not keep reinventing the definition in a way that weakens the regulation,” he said.

He also criticised the proposed size of the warning, which would be one point larger than the back-of-pack nutrition information. “If the nutrition table is printed in tiny type, making the warning one point larger does not make it prominent,” he said, calling for the size of the warning to be linked to the principal display area of the package.

India has mandatory nutrition information on packaged foods but has never had a mandatory front-of-pack warning specifically flagging products high in sugar, salt or saturated fat. FSSAI proposed HFSS and front-of-pack nutrition regulations in 2022, but the process has remained stalled.

House panel chief says didn't intend to question Modi govt.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MP Ganesh Singh, the chief of the Parliamentary Committee on Welfare of Other Backward Classes (OBCs), said on Saturday that his statement on the issue of the OBC creamy layer income test and equivalence of posts was “at no point intended to question the commitment of the government led by Hon'ble Prime Minister Narendra Modi towards the welfare and empowerment of the OBC community”.

The clarification came a day after he told *The Hindu* that the issue of establishing equivalence of posts and the equal application of the income test for OBC reservation appeared to be stuck between two Union ministries.

On Saturday, Mr. Singh said his intention was to “seek clarity and uniformity on the technical and administrative aspects” of the issue so that eligible candidates do not face “avoidable difficulties”. He said it was “not a comment on the government's commitment to OBC welfare”, and added that the “stalemate” between the two ministries had arisen because of a UPA-era letter that he claimed had obfuscated



BJP MP Ganesh Singh

the issue, referring to the 2004 clarificatory letter issued by the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT).

This amid the recent furore over the Centre's submissions to the Supreme Court that it was finding it “extremely difficult” to implement the court's judgment settling the issue on March 11.

In March, the Supreme Court ruled that the DoPT was practising “hostile discrimination” in applying the income test differently to OBC candidates with parents in government service and those with parents in jobs where equivalence with government posts had not been established. It noted that for the latter, income from salaries was being included, while this was not the case for the former, and directed the government to create supernumerary posts for OBC candidates who were denied ‘non-creamy layer’ status based on this.

events recorded during limited post-relocation monitoring.

Other raptor species, including the black kite (*Milvus migrans*) and crested serpent eagle (*Spilornis cheela*), were also recorded at the relocated site.

“Our findings indicated that relocating carcass dumping sites away from hazardous power infrastructure can be a practical conservation measure for reducing electrocution risk and could potentially be applied in other affected areas,” Mr. Anver of the Dehradun-based Wildlife Institute of India told *The Hindu*.

However, no studies have been conducted after 2015.

NLUD students back NLSIU peers' right to convocation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In an extended multi-city chain of support, the Governing Council of the Student Bar Council of National Law University Delhi (NLUD) on Saturday expressed solidarity with the graduating students of the National Law School of India University (NLSIU), Bengaluru, appealing against the cancellation of their 34th annual convocation.

The NLSIU convocation was cancelled after graduating students objected to having Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Bar Council of India (BCI) chairperson Manan Kumar Mishra at the event. The NLSIU students, in turn, were acting in solidarity with students at NALSAR, Hyderabad who had kicked off the original storm when they opposed the CJI's presence at their own convocation, in protest against his use of terms

like ‘cockroach’ and ‘parasites’ in the court room, as well as his initial response to police action against last month's student protests. The BCI had suddenly intervened with an aborted attempt to ban NALSAR students from professional enrolment. The NLSIU students had objected to the BCI's conduct, and sought an unconditional apology from Mr. Mishra.

On August 27, the NLSIU had informed graduating students that their degrees would be conferred in absentia after due approvals by governing bodies, and gave them the option of getting their certificates by courier or collecting them on campus.

The NLUD student body on Saturday urged the NLSIU administration to reconsider its decision and ensure that graduating students were afforded a fair opportunity to have their convocation conducted without compromising their right of expression.

Fish workers plan protest on livelihood concerns

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Fish workers who are part of the All India Fish Workers Federation will protest near Jantar Mantar here on Monday, urging the Union government to address their livelihood issues and provide them with health and accident insurance cover. They will also submit a memorandum to Union Fisheries Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh, with a charter of demands, including control over multinational companies engaged in fishing.

The Union government must withdraw the “blue economy policy” as it subjugates the sea and the coast to multinational companies, the federation's leaders, R. Prasad, and Lok Sabha MP V. Selvaraj, said in a statement. They urged the Union government to provide land and houses to all fishing families.

The children of fish workers must get reservation and grants in higher education, and job reservation in the Indian Navy and Coast Guard, they said. Alleging that fish workers were tortured by foreign countries on the pretext of violating maritime boundaries, they demanded that the Centre must take steps to avoid such incidents.

INBRIEF



Nepal seeks to import power earlier from India after floods

In the wake of the devastating flash flood that severely impacted Nepal's power infrastructure, Kathmandu has asked India to give the requisite approvals for the transmission of electricity to Nepal earlier than usual, senior officials in the Union Power Ministry said on Saturday. "Nepal has asked that India advance import approvals, starting from September this year, in view of the generation deficits caused by this disaster. The concerned authorities are processing the requests," an official said. According to officials, India is willing to provide any additional power that Nepal may need. Nepal usually imports electricity from India during the winter months.

Ather unveils new bike Konarc, battery platform

Ather Energy, Bengaluru-based electric two-wheeler manufacturer, announced Konarc, Ather's newest scooter; Ather True Health, a comprehensive vehicle health report and resale-value assessment; the fifth-generation Ather Bedrock Battery platform and Ather Node, a charging solution for apartment communities. The announcements are expected to address key barriers consumers continue to face with electric two-wheelers, from everyday usability and battery safety to long-term battery health, resale value and access to convenient home charging, according to the EV firm. Konarc, the first product built on Ather's new EL platform, is targeted at mainstream Indian riders, focusing on ride comfort, stability, everyday usability, and serviceability. Konarc is available in six variants.

'No material price hit on CBG on revised offtake framework'

Addressing concerns over compressed biogas (CBG) turning expensive with the revised offtake price, the Union Petroleum Ministry assured the pricing cushioned with government-funded support and stacking with substantially wider gas pool would avert any material price impact. The Union Cabinet August 6 okayed GOBARDhan scheme that introduced CBG offtake price of ₹2,110/metric million British thermal unit. Responding to a media report, it said the revised pricing framework seeks to provide CBG producers with a "stable and viable" price that would help them operate "sustainably". The Ministry clarified full offtake price would not be recovered from gas consumers. It explained the government would provide an affordability cushion of ₹10 per kilogram of CBG.

IRDAI panel bats for simpler, easier-to-use health covers

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD



The committee wanted to minimise issues arising from inadequate disclosures.

A sub-committee on health insurance under Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) Chairman Ajay Seth underscored the need to make health covers simpler, more transparent and easier for policyholders to understand and use. Simplification of policy wording, strengthening underwriting at the point of sale to minimise claim issues arising from inadequate disclosures and facilitating hassle-free claim settlements were discussed by the Sub-Committee, of the Insurance Advisory Committee (IAC) at its meeting on August 28. The role of insurers, intermediaries, agents and TPAs in supporting policyholders at hospitals was also discussed, IRDAI said. It also considered steps to encourage insurers and hospitals to join the National Health Claims Exchange (NHCC), including possible sops linked to onboarding, payments and faster settlement and incentivising policyholders who undergo periodic health check-ups. The meeting emphasised on the need for stan-

dardisation and enriching industry data to support evidence-based policy interventions. Noting claim assessment and grievance outcomes should not focus only on settlement ratios but also on absolute values, it wanted insurers to mull publishing standard treatment guidelines and treatment package rates for aiding more informed choices by policyholders. **Review of exclsions** Among other things, the sub-committee favoured a further review of exclusions in the Customer Information Sheet to improve clarity and customer trust. Setting the backdrop for the meeting was the report of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health and Family Welfare,

HDFC Bank MD&CEO Jagdishan not to seek reappointment

The private sector lender said board has decided to fast-track the process for the selection and appointment of his successor well within time

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Sashidhar Jagdishan, HDFC Bank's MD & CEO has conveyed his decision not to seek his re-appointment. India's largest private sector bank said in an exchange filing. "At its meeting held today, the board of directors took note of Mr. Sashidhar Jagdishan's communication not to seek reappointment. Despite persuasion, Mr. Jagdishan reiterated his decision to not seek reappointment. Accordingly, he shall retire from the services of the Bank upon the close of business hours on October 26, 2026," the lender said. "The board deeply appreciated his commitment, leadership, contribution to the growth and stability of the bank and his role in the successful completion of one of the largest mergers in corporate India. The board conveyed its best wishes to him in his future endeavours," it added.

Selection fast-tracked The bank said it's board has decided to fast-track the process for selection and appointment of his successor well within time. Mr. Jagdishan had taken over as the MD & CEO after Aditya Puri's retirement. Sashi, as he's known to friends and colleagues, joined HDFC Bank in 1996



Sashidhar Jagdishan

and played a critical role in its growth ever since. Recently, he had come under criticism for the bank's stock's underperformance in the market and faced allegations of violating corporate governance norms, which the bank had denied. In the last week, the stock had fallen to a multi-year low, analysts said. Earlier this year, the previous part-time chairman of the bank, Atanu Chakraborty, had resigned citing ethical grounds and following this, Mr. Sashidhar came under a cloud.

Slapped fines Recently, Mr. Jagdishan, the bank's CFO and one more top official were fined by the bank for "business overreach" after running an internal review into the its deposit arrangements with Maharashtra State Road Deve-

lopment Corporation for garnering deposits in 2017 and 2021. The Special Disciplinary Committee of Independent Directors had concluded the conduct of the employees involved constituted business overreach rather than any mala fide action, personal enrichment, or improper motive. The board also communicated the matter to the Reserve Bank of India. The RBI is also believed to have expressed discomfort with his continuation at the top post. With less than two months to go before his tenure ends and no green signal coming from the board, and the regulator, Mr. Jagdishan preferred to opt out, it is learnt. Having started his tenure at the bank as a manager in the finance department, he became business head - finance in 1999 and in 2008, the chief financial officer of the bank. **High cost of funds** Prior to HDFC Bank, he worked with Deutsche Bank AG, Mumbai, for a period of three years. It was during Mr. Jagdishan's tenure that HDFC Ltd. was merged with HDFC Bank in 2023, and the merger remained a drag on the bank's performance due to the high cost of funds raised by HDFC Ltd, the mortgage lender.

GST Council to meet on Sept. 12

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The meeting of the GST Council, chaired by Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, is scheduled for September 12. The 57th meeting of the

GST Council is scheduled in New Delhi and will be preceded by an officer's meeting on September 11, according to an office memorandum circulated by the Council secretariat. The council, chaired by Ms. Sitharaman and com-

prising State Finance Ministers, will meet after a gap of over a year. The 56th GST Council meeting took place in 2025, during which the Centre and States decided on a major restructuring of GST rates and slabs.



Long journey: Singapore Airlines said SIA and Tatas had recognised that the AI transformation programme would take time. REUTERS

Singapore Airlines to weigh capital infusion in AI

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

With questions being raised about Air India's (AI) future amid mounting losses and delay in turnaround plan, Singapore Airlines (SIA) reiterated its long-term commitment to AI in which it holds 25.1% stake. SIA said investment in AI received the full attention of its board and any requests for additional capital for AI would be evaluated under the group's disciplined capital allocation framework. This is considering AI business strategy, the group's operating cash flow and the investment needs for new aircraft and products, SIA said in a Letter to the editor of Singapore's *The Business Times*. The publication had published an article titled "Singapore Airlines faces some bleak choices as it lies trapped in Air India's money pit."

It asked if SIA should just cut losses and walk away from AI when additional infusion of \$1.5 billion was needed out of which \$375 million was to come from SIA. **Huge losses** In the last fiscal, the majority Tata-owned airline suffered losses of over ₹20,000 crore. Tata Sons board reportedly asked chairman N. Chandrasekaran to arrest the losses. "The SIA Group's investment in AI is aligned with its long-term multi-hub strategy to enable direct

participation in the growth of a key market like India," SIA said in its response to *The Business Times* article.

Huge market Stating India was projected to be the world's third-largest economy by 2030, SIA said the country was the world's third-largest aviation market by passenger traffic, which was expected to treble by 2044 from 2024 levels. It stated SIA and Tata had recognised AI transformation programme would take time.

Many challenges "In the past year, AI had also had to contend with the prolonged Pakistan airspace closure to Indian carriers since April 2025, the impact of the tragic AI171 accident in June 2025, the depreciation of the Indian rupee against the U.S. dollar, the loss of a key market due to the Middle East conflict and sustained high fuel prices," SIA said. "Nonetheless, AI is making tangible progress across customer experience, fleet renewal, network growth and operational performance," it said. Highlighting AI continued to take delivery of new aircraft and retrofit existing aircraft to enhance customer offering, SIA said, "this approach supported sustainable growth for the SIA Group and long-term shareholders' returns." Meanwhle, Singapore's Temasek, the majority shareholder of SIA, backed the airline's investment in AI.

Apparel exporters worry over cotton, yarn price hikes

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

Increase in cotton and yarn prices in the last six months is impacting the apparel value chain leading to even cancellation of garment export orders, claim apparel exporters. Chairman of the Apparel Export Promotion Council (AEP) A. Sakthivel said export of yarn and increase in cotton yarn prices is affecting the competitiveness of the apparel sector and hence, the Union government should regulate yarn exports. Cotton yarn prices have increased by around 60% since January. With increase in export of Indian cotton and cotton yarn to apparel-producing countries such as Bangladesh and Vietnam, Indian garment manufacturers are losing their competitiveness, he said. R. Sakthivel, a garment exporter in Tiruppur, said cotton yarn prices rose by ₹7 a kg in March and in August by more than ₹17 a kg. In the last six months, the prices have gone up by ₹60 to ₹70 a kg. Garment exporters have entered into price contracts with the foreign buyers and cannot revise them now. Due to recent supply and production issues in Bangladesh, some of the major international apparel importers began looking at India as an alternative sourcing destination. However, with continuous increase in yarn prices, price gap between India and Bangladesh widened and some of these orders were diverted to competing countries, he said. Textile mills are revising yarn prices frequently and without prior notice, while MSME units cannot buy yarn in bulk, say garment exporters. However, textile mills contend that hike in cotton prices is the reason for jump in yarn prices. Prices of the widely used Shankar 6 variety of cotton jumped 26% in the last six months.

Tata Sons secures RoC nod for 3-month extension for AGM

Aneesh Phadnis
MUMBAI

Tata Sons has secured an extension from the Registrar of Companies (RoC) to hold its annual general meeting by December-end, a company executive confirmed on Saturday. They submitted an application for an extension as a lack of quorum had resulted in the adjournment of its shareholders' meeting on August 18. As per the Companies Act of 2013, an AGM must be held within six months of the end of the financial year (that is, by September end) and within 15 months of the last AGM. The application was made under section 96(1) of the Companies Act, and consent was granted for a three-month extension until the end of December.

Affects accounts The deferral of the AGM has affected the finalisation of Tata Sons' FY26 accounts, the declaration of a ₹4,474 crore dividend and the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as a director retiring by rotation. The quorum issue arose

as Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT), is restricted by the Charity Commissioner of Maharashtra (CCM) from holding meetings. The Articles of Association of Tata Sons require participation of a joint representative of SRTT and Sir Dorabji Tata Trust for fulfilment of the quorum. Since SRTT can't meet, the quorum requirement can't be fulfilled. Separately, SRTT made another plea to the CCM to lift the curbs it imposed in May. The action was initiated on complaints of violations of the Maharashtra Public Trusts Act. The trustees have now petitioned the CCM to grant relief as charitable activities, such as the disbursement of funds, are on hold. The trust has to adhere to statutory norms and needs to submit annual accounts and investment declaration to the CCM. Importantly, the curbs are delaying decisions on AGM participation and the formation of a selection committee to choose the next chairman of Tata Sons after Mr. Chandrasekaran's term ends in February. (The writer is with *The Hindu businessline*)



Government of Karnataka

Department of Collegiate Education

No. 1, Unnatha Shikshana Soudha, Sheshadri Road, Bengaluru – 560 001
Phone: 080-22223906, email: dce.tenders2017@gmail.com

No.: DCE-ADBP0GEN/13/2026-ADBP (Computer No.2266781)

Date: 29.08.2026

E-TENDER NOTIFICATION

The Commissioner for Collegiate Education, Bangalore hereby invites bids in Two-Cover system through e-Procurement portal from eligible bidders for the following Tender. The Tender Documents with detailed terms and conditions may be obtained from the website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>.

Tender Schedules are as below

Sl. No.	Tender Name & Number	Date of Floating Tender on e-Procurement Portal	Date and Time of pre-bid meeting	Last date and Time for bidding through eprocurement portal
1.	Tender No: DCE/2026-27/IND0079 "GFGC-Lab-06 Goods for Physics and Electronics laboratories under Karnataka Higher Education Transformation Project"	29.08.2026	05.09.2026 @ 03.00 PM	28.09.2026 11.00 AM

Sd/-

Commissioner of Collegiate Education, Bengaluru

DIPR/CP/2489/NR/2026-27



DIRECTORATE OF ECONOMICS AND STATISTICS,
ODISHA, BHUBANESWAR

Request for Proposal (RFP)

Extension in due date for submission of BID for the following

SI No.	RFP No & Description
1	RFP No: DES-NSS-RFP-01/Dtd.10.08.2026, for hiring of Manpower Agency to provide manpower support to conduct 81st Round National Sample Survey, EMD : ₹ 9,00,000/- ; Tender Fee : ₹ 5,000/-

RFP available at : <https://des.odisha.gov.in/>:
Due date for submission of bid : **5th September 2026 (05.00 PM)**,
Opening of Bid : **5th September 2026 (05.30 PM)**

Sd/-

DIRECTOR

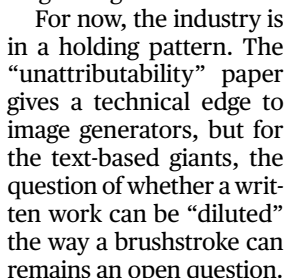
21001/1/2627

OIPR-21001/21002/1/26-27/0001

D.P. Kasbekar is a retired scientist.

Blaming climate change for extreme weather has limits

How massive data pools remove ‘smoking gun’ of AI training



By analysing data from 2,344 counties in China between 2014 and 2023, researchers found policies promoting large-scale solar farms also supported ‘inferior greening’: while solar installations increased the amount of green on the ground, the new growth was often dense and lacked the variety of natural habitats that supports many bird species. The study found these consequences were most pronounced in non-desert regions, so its authors recommended clustering large solar projects in desert areas.



AI and earthquakes

predict. They have no way to say if a quake of a given strength will occur at a given place at a given time. Instead, they estimate the probability of a quake happening in a place over many years based on the long-term history and behaviour of faults there. Scientists are also working on early-warning systems that can give people up to tens of seconds of advance notice before the ground starts to shake violently. AI can help significantly improve forecasting. However, it cannot improve predictions because the data for predictions do not exist.

Why is FSSAI tightening the rules on food claims?

How is it cracking down on misleading food claims? What does this mean for companies and consumers?

Bindu Shajan Perappadan

The story so far:
Earlier this month, following a notice from the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI), Mondelez India withdrew certain health and nutrient-comparison claims for Bournvita and removed the related advertisements from e-commerce platforms. The action is part of a wider regulatory push. FSSAI said it has issued more than 150 notices to food companies in recent months over misleading advertisements, false claims, and labelling non-compliance. The list includes some of the country’s biggest packaged-food and beverage companies, such as Nestlé India, PepsiCo, Coca-Cola India, Abbott India, Red Bull India, Danone India, Mondelez India, Ferrero India, and Kenvue.

Why does Bournvita matter?
Bournvita has long been marketed to parents in the context of children’s nutrition. The product came under intense public scrutiny in 2023 over its sugar content and claims about nutritional benefits. The latest action does not, by itself, establish that Bournvita is unsafe. The regulatory issue is different – whether particular health or nutrient-comparison claims are adequately supported and whether the way they are presented could give consumers a misleading impression. That distinction is important. As a senior government official explained, “Food regulation is not limited to checking whether a product contains permitted ingredients. It also governs how a product’s nutritional qualities and benefits are communicated.” He added that a statement suggesting that a product helps deliver a particular health outcome, for instance, can create expectations beyond what its ingredient composition or available evidence may justify.

Why is FSSAI taking issue with ‘100%’?
The Bournvita action sits alongside another FSSAI concern – the use of absolute-sounding words such as “100%”. In May 2025, FSSAI advised food businesses to stop using “100%” on food labels, packaging, and promotional material. Its reasoning was that such language could convey a “false sense of absolute purity or superiority” to consumers. The significance goes beyond coconut oil or atta. In a crowded packaged-food market, words such as “pure”, “natural”, “healthy”, “immunity-boosting”, and “100%” are powerful marketing devices. They can influence purchasing decisions even before a consumer examines the nutrition panel or ingredient list. Recent corrective actions show the range of claims under scrutiny. Amway India has removed “100%” from its “100% Pure Coconut Oil” packaging and promotional material, and dropped the “Energy Drink” descriptor from its caffeinated XS products. Kerala-based Juza Foods has agreed to withdraw claims relating to immunity, stronger bones, and comparative calcium benefits from its baby-food products.

Why is e-commerce part of the crackdown?
One important change is that enforcement is no longer confined to the physical package on a supermarket shelf. FSSAI has extended its scrutiny to e-commerce platforms and food-service establishments, issuing notices to online marketplaces as well as restaurants and other food businesses. This matters because online product pages can carry claims, images, and promotional language that differ from what appears on the physical package. For consumers, the distinction is increasingly blurred – they may decide to purchase a product based on an online banner or product description rather than by reading the label in a shop, the FSSAI said. “Our enforcement reflects how food advertising has changed,” it added.

What is the regulator trying to change?
At its core, the campaign is about moving from broad marketing language to claims that can be demonstrated. This is particularly relevant as India confronts rising concerns over obesity and unhealthy diets. FSSAI itself has linked its recent food-safety messaging with a wider push for healthier eating and action against obesity.

How effective are these corrections?
A company can remove a claim after receiving a notice, but consumers may already have encountered it for years. Advertisements may disappear from one platform but their messaging may be present elsewhere. Online listings can also change rapidly. All this makes sustained monitoring important. FSSAI’s challenge now is to make compliance routine rather than a temporary response to regulatory scrutiny. For consumers, it is important to remember that a health claim on a food packet is a claim, not a guarantee.

Why is Meta’s \$17.1-billion settlement significant?

What was the lawsuit by 29 U.S. States against Meta about? What did the trial reveal about the impact of Instagram and Facebook on children? What changes has Meta agreed to make? Will the settlement lead to meaningful change? Why are critics still raising concerns?

Joan Sony Cherian

The story so far:
On August 26, Meta reached a landmark settlement of up to \$17.1 billion with at least 47 U.S. States, ending a lawsuit which accused the tech giant of hiding harms caused by its platforms to children, violating child privacy laws, and deliberately using tactics to keep teens engaged or ‘addicted’ to its platforms. The settlement also requires Meta to make changes to the safety features on Instagram and Facebook.

What was the lawsuit about?
The lawsuit, brought by 29 States, alleged that Meta regularly collected data on children under the age of 13 without parental consent, thus breaking various State and federal privacy laws. It also alleged that the company deliberately designed platforms to be addictive in order to keep teens engaged, which led to depression and anxiety. The suit accused Meta of refusing to “abandon its use of known harmful features” and focusing solely on profits and financial gain over the safety of children.

What happened during the trial?
The matter went to trial on August 18, 2026, in Oakland, California. During the trial, internal documents from the tech giant were showcased, pointing towards addictive behaviours among teens using Instagram. There were also witness testimonies from former Meta employees stating that the company had repeatedly ignored warning signs. According to Meta’s own company documents, a Facebook study found that 13.5% of British teenage girls surveyed said their suicidal thoughts had become more frequent

The lawsuit alleged that Meta deliberately designed platforms to be addictive in order to keep teens engaged, which led to depression and anxiety

after joining Instagram. A study by internal researchers of the company on Instagram had found that some of the problems, especially related to social comparison, were issues specific to only Instagram and not social media as a whole. As per a *Wall Street Journal* investigation, the internal researchers had said that while other media mostly focus on the face and ‘jokey’ filters (SnapChat), Instagram focuses on the body and lifestyle, which lead to comparisons and feelings of inadequacy. A key witness for the States was Arturo Béjar, a former Meta safety engineer, who stated on record that Meta was aware of the harm its products caused children, which included exposing them to content from sexual predators as well as violent and graphic images. He said that while he had repeatedly raised the issue to various Facebook and Instagram executives, nothing was done to resolve it. He raised concerns about features such as infinite scroll, which keep users engaged while generating revenue for the company through targeted ads. Meta has denied all these allegations. It said that the statements from documents were cherry-picked and taken out of context. Paul Schmidt, a lawyer for Meta, said that the company had undertaken various measures to address teens’ over-use of Instagram, and that it had disabled more than 1 million accounts of young users. During the trial, Adam Mosseri, the CEO of Instagram, denied allegations that his company hid negative information from the public. Even after the settlement, Meta has denied any wrong-doing.

Is Meta the only company facing such lawsuits?
Meta and other social media giants such as Alphabet (the parent company of Google and YouTube) and TikTok have been facing a series of lawsuits over youth social media ‘addiction’ and children’s safety. Earlier this year, a Los Angeles jury found Meta and Alphabet liable for \$6 million in damages due to the ‘addictive’ design of their platforms. The plaintiff said that she had become ‘addicted’ to social media, mainly YouTube and Instagram, at a young age, which led to a deterioration in her mental health. In March, a New Mexico court ordered Meta to pay \$375 million for misleading users about the dangers its platforms pose to children. New Mexico sued Meta in 2023 alleging that the company “steered” children and teens towards sexually explicit, graphic, and violent content which exposed them to offers of solicitation and even trafficking. TikTok settled three cases brought by teens

who alleged that using the platform had led them to suffer from self-harm, anxiety, depression, addiction, and eating disorders. Earlier this month, it also reached a \$400 million settlement with the U.S. Department of Justice, which alleged that the company violated federal laws on children’s privacy.

Can social media be addictive?
The American Society of Addiction Medicine defines an addiction as a “treatable, chronic medical disease involving complex interactions among brain circuits, genetics, the environment, and an individual’s life experiences. People with addiction use substances or engage in behaviors that become compulsive and often continue despite harmful consequences.” Social media is sometimes described as a form of behavioural addiction since it makes you engage in an action which you know to be harmful, yet cannot stop. A review paper published by Jashvini Amirthalingam and Anika Khera in *Cureus* in 2024 states that social media “addiction” is shaped by a combination of “psychological factors, such as low self-esteem and mental health issues, technological mechanisms like infinite scrolling and personalised notifications, and social influences, including peer pressure and exposure to idealised content”. A potential “treatment” for the same would include cognitive therapy, educational awareness, and parental strategies such as placing limits and boundaries on social media use. However, social media has not been medically recognised as an addiction. Therefore, there aren’t any clear cut guidelines on how to diagnose, measure, and treat such ‘behaviours’. This point was a key argument by Meta’s lawyers who claimed that social media addiction was not an established psychiatric condition.

What next?
Under the settlement, Meta has agreed to introduce several safety features for teens, including a default two-hour daily limit which they can turn off only with parental permission; ‘school’ and ‘night’ modes that mute notifications; the choice to curate a feed which is not driven by algorithms; blocking of ‘likes’ on teens’ accounts and those they interact with in order to reduce comparison; and blocking of extreme make-up filters. Meta said that the two-hour daily time limit and night mode feature would work only if other social media platforms also follow suit. The settlement has been called historic as it mandates Meta to make concrete changes regarding safety measures for children and teens. The payouts will also enable the States to address children’s mental health concerns. However, some critics state that since Meta has not changed its revenue model, which still prioritises endless scrolling and targeted ads, such rudimentary safety features will not lead to fundamental change.

Can an accused be denied a copy of the FIR?

Does the law require the police to give an accused a copy of the FIR? What have courts said about an accused’s right to access an FIR? Can the police withhold an FIR from the accused in certain cases? Why does timely access to an FIR matter for an accused?

Aaratrika Bhaumik

The story so far:
The Supreme Court on August 25 ordered the Ghaziabad Police to provide independent journalist Abhishek Upadhyay with a copy of the FIR and CCTV footage in a road-rage case registered against him. Mr. Upadhyay, who had reported on alleged irregularities in donations to the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, claimed that he was being falsely implicated over his reportage and that the police had failed to provide him with the FIR despite repeated requests.

Why did the court have to intervene?
On August 20, Mr. Upadhyay alleged that a police team arrived at his residence and informed him that a case had been registered at the Indrapuram police station over road rage and abusive behaviour. In a post on X, he claimed that despite repeatedly seeking a copy of the FIR, the police initially sent him a page containing neither the sections invoked nor details of the alleged offence, and later shared an older FIR registered against him in Lucknow. Mr. Upadhyay then approached the Supreme Court, alleging that the case was based on concocted allegations and intended to harass him for his journalism. He sought a copy of the FIR and quashing of the proceedings or,

The Supreme directed that FIRs be uploaded on police websites within 24 hours of registration or, where no such website exists, on the official website of the State government

alternatively, transfer of the probe to an independent agency. A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant directed the Ghaziabad Police Commissioner to provide him with the FIR and CCTV footage and file a compliance report by September 7. It also protected him from arrest and allowed him to approach the jurisdictional High Court for further relief.

What do statutory provisions stipulate?
The Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 (BNSS), does not require the police to furnish the accused with an FIR immediately upon registration. Section 173(2) requires a copy to be given “forthwith” and free of cost to the informant or victim, but does not mention the accused. The statute provides for the accused to receive the FIR only at a later stage, after the investigation culminates in the filing of a chargesheet before the magistrate. Section 230 requires the magistrate to furnish the accused with copies of documents relied upon by the prosecution, including the FIR and chargesheet, within 14 days of their appearance or production before the court. The BNSS does not address an accused person’s right to access the FIR before this stage, including during the investigation. Judicial precedents have, however, recognised the right of an accused to obtain the FIR soon after its registration.

What have courts held on access to FIRs?
In *Court on its Own Motion through Mr. Ajay Choudhary v. State* (2010), the Delhi High Court laid down a mechanism for an accused to obtain an FIR during the investigation, before the stage contemplated under Section 230 of the BNSS. The court also directed the Delhi Police to upload FIRs on its website within 24 hours of registration. FIRs involving sensitive offences can, however, be withheld through a reasoned decision by an officer not below the rank of DCP. In *Rama Nand Rathore v. State of Himachal Pradesh* (2014), the Himachal Pradesh High Court held that a person who suspects that they have been named in an FIR can seek a certified copy from the police, which must supply it within 24 hours. It also directed FIRs to be

uploaded online within the same period, barring sensitive cases. In *Youth Bar Association of India v. Union of India* (2016), the Supreme Court gave these directives pan-India effect and reiterated that an accused is entitled to access the FIR before the stage prescribed under Section 207 of the CrPC (now Section 230 of the BNSS). The Court directed that FIRs be uploaded on police websites within 24 hours of registration or, where no such website exists, on the official website of the State government. Where unavoidable difficulties delay publication, the 24-hour deadline may be extended to 48, or up to 72 hours for geographical connectivity issues. The court, however, carved out an exception to the online publication requirement for FIRs involving offences “sensitive in nature”.

What is the ‘sensitive offence’ exemption?
The apex court identified sexual offences, cases under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012, and terror offences as examples of “sensitive” offences, while clarifying that the list was not exhaustive. The decision cannot be taken by a police officer below the rank of Deputy Superintendent of Police or its equivalent. A person aggrieved by it can approach the Superintendent of Police or an equivalent officer, who must constitute a three-member committee to decide the grievance within three days. Even where an FIR is withheld on grounds of sensitivity, the accused or an authorised representative can apply for a certified copy to the magistrate to whom the FIR has been forwarded, who must provide it in three days.

What are the implications?
Delhi-based advocate Nipun Saxena says police officials routinely fail to comply with the Supreme Court’s directive to upload FIRs through the Crime and Criminal Tracking Network and Systems. “Once an FIR is registered and the criminal law is set in motion, the accused is entitled to seek pre-trial remedies such as quashing of the FIR or anticipatory bail. Without access to the FIR, these remedies cannot be effectively pursued,” he says. Mr. Saxena adds that the Supreme Court’s ruling recognised that an accused cannot be made to wait until the framing of charges to know the offences alleged against them, as this would undermine the right to a fair trial and the principles of natural justice.

PROFILES

A Himalayan tragedy

The Bhotekoshi flood

Scientists investigate how a high-altitude rock-and-ice avalanche may have triggered one of Nepal's most devastating floods; while experts have not directly attributed this event to climate change, they note that rising temperatures are warming the Himalayas and accelerating glacier melt

Sanjeev Satgainya

Ramesh Kumar, a journalist based in Kathmandu, on Thursday posted a photograph of a clock tower, its hands stopped at 09.29.

“A clock that would never show the time again,” he wrote on X, formerly Twitter. “Betrawati.”

Mr. Kumar had reached Betrawati in Nuwakot district, a town devastated by the previous day’s flood in the Bhotekoshi River in neighbouring Rasuwa district, which borders Tibet. After touring Betrawati, where he was born and raised, he made a grim assessment: “Will Betrawati ever revive as a bazaar again? Almost impossible.”

The extraordinary velocity and scale of the flash flood in the Bhotekoshi River at around 8.40 a.m. on Wednesday has left more than 600 dead and close to 2,500 missing, including foreign nationals, mostly from India.

The Nepal government promptly got into action, mobilising personnel from the Nepal Army, Nepal Police and the Armed Police Force, as it mounted a massive search-and-rescue operation.

Scientists, meanwhile, struggled to piece together the chain of events and determine the origin of the flood, as they wondered about the enormity of the disaster, with some describing it as the worst since the 2015 earthquake.

On the origin, the Nepalese and Chinese sides have concluded that the source was in the Langtang Lirung area. Identifying the exact point where the initial collapse occurred, and which side of the border it was on, may be difficult.

According to an official at Nepal’s Department of Hydrology and Meteorology, satellite imagery shared by the Chinese side pointed to a combination of an ice avalanche, permafrost movement and a rockslide along the Nepal-China border, with the rockslide occurring on the Chinese side and its impact extending into Nepal.

“The avalanche originated on the Nepalese side of the territory, but very close to the boundary, and induced



AFF

flooding that crossed the Nepal-China border, causing extensive damage on both sides,” said Binod Parajuli, a senior divisional hydrologist at the department’s flood forecasting division.

The location scientists are pointing to is in the Lhende Khola, a transboundary high-altitude river that originates in Gyirong County in Tibet and flows south into Nepal, where it is a tributary of the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli river systems.

Flooding in the Bhotekoshi River is not uncommon. Last year, in July, a flood – caused without rainfall – in the Bhotekoshi wreaked damage and destruction. Scientists later concluded that the disaster was associated with a glacial lake outburst flood (GLOF).

Different angle

While scientists initially considered whether this year’s flood could also have been linked to a GLOF, its velocity and ferocity, which washed away villages downstream in three districts – Rasuwa, Nuwakot and Dhading – prompted experts to examine it from a different angle.

Dr. Ranjan Kumar Dahal, an associate professor at the Himalayan Geodisaster Research Centre at the Central Department of Geology, Tribhuvan University, described the mass movement that triggered the flood as a sturzstrom.

“A sturzstrom is a massive rock avalanche in which a large volume of rock suddenly collapses and moves at extremely high speed over a long distance,” Mr. Dahal told *The Hindu* from Trishuli, another area hit hard by Wednesday’s flood. “In high-mountain environments, when rock is mixed with ice, snow, firn and frozen soil, it can be understood as a rock-ice avalanche.”

Rasuwagadhi in Rasuwa is a border checkpoint through which most of Nepal’s trade with China takes place. From May to September, hundreds of pilgrims use this border point to cross into Tibet for the Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage. Indians make up the largest share of the pilgrims.

It could take weeks, if not months, to assess the full scale of the damage, officials said, adding that the toll could further rise.

The International Federation of Red Cross said the remoteness of the affected areas, combined with damaged infrastructure, was making it harder both to assess the full scale of the disaster and to deliver assistance to people who need it.

“Current estimates suggest around 93,000 people may have been affected,” it said. “Many homes have been severely damaged, cutting off some of the worst-affected communities.”

In the aftermath of the disaster, two more crucial questions have also emerged – whether the early-warning systems were activated and whether climate change had a role in the disaster. Experts say early-warning systems had worked as intended but were rendered ineffective given the staggering speed of the flood.

Kamal Kishore, the head of the UN Office for Disaster Risk Reduction, said the floods had once again highlighted how fragile mountain ecosystems are and how challenging it is to set up early-warning systems in mountain environments.

Scientists have not ruled out the

impact of climate change, saying the rising temperatures are causing the Himalayas to warm and glaciers to melt faster, but they stopped short of directly linking the disaster to global warming.

“We had not seen such a disaster in Nepal involving a sturzstrom. However, in 2021, there was a similar event in India,” said Mr. Dahal, referring to the Chamoli disaster in Uttarakhand, where a bedrock failure beneath a glacier triggered a massive rock-ice avalanche that subsequently transformed into a debris flow and flood.

The 2021 Chamoli event has been scientifically described as a rock-and-ice avalanche and, in some literature, explicitly as a sturzstrom. Research found that more than 25 million cubic metres of rock and ice broke loose high in the Uttarakhand Himalaya before moving rapidly downstream.

Catastrophic sturzstrom

“A sturzstrom begins when an unstable rock-ice slope suddenly collapses. The collapsing mass rapidly accelerates, fragments and mixes with ice and snow,” Mr. Dahal explained.

“Pressure and friction can generate meltwater, which may increase lubrication within the moving mass and along its base, reducing resistance and contributing to exceptionally long runoff,” he added.

According to him, this process can unfold within just a few minutes.

“As it moves downslope, it may incorporate more ice, snow, rock, soil and water, potentially transforming into a massive debris flow before finally depositing its material,” he said.

Meanwhile, rescue operations have continued on the fourth day, with Prime Minister Balendra Shah saying more than 15,000 personnel have been deployed.

For communities along the Bhotekoshi-Trishuli corridor, the immediate priorities are finding the missing, restoring access and assessing whether some of the places destroyed by the flood can be rebuilt at all.

It’s a race against time.

THE GIST

- ▼ The flood devastated riverside towns across Rasuwa, Nuwakot and Dhading districts, burying places like Betrawati and Trishuli under metres of mud, boulders and silt
- ▼ Nepal mobilised a massive search-and-rescue operation involving personnel from the Army, police and armed police force
- ▼ The remoteness of affected areas and damaged access routes have severely hampered both damage assessment and delivery of aid

Trump’s crypto U-turn

World Liberty Financial

Investments from a top UAE official into U.S. President’s crypto enterprise attract criticisms of conflict of interest and foreign influence

Nivedita Varadarajan

U.S. President Donald Trump has built a business empire spanning real estate, casinos and entertainment. His family’s growing crypto dealings are now facing mounting criticism over conflicts of interest and foreign influence.

A top United Arab Emirates official holds a stake in the family’s latest venture: a planned crypto bank now drawing scrutiny over foreign ties to a sitting President. The *Wall Street Journal* has reported that Sheikh Tahnoon bin Zayed al Nahyan, the UAE’s national security adviser, and his co-investors own a major stake in the company behind that bank.

Earlier this month, Office of the Comptroller of the Currency gave conditional approval to World Liberty Financial, backed by Mr. Trump’s family and close allies, to set up a federally chartered U.S. trust bank to issue, redeem and safeguard a dollar-backed stablecoin, USDI.

Mr. Tahnoon and his co-investors own 49% stake in bank’s holding company, the *Journal* reported. “The shareholder structure of the bank’s holding company, called WLTC Holdings, is the same as World Liberty’s, though Tahnoon and his co-investors used a different entity – called StringZ Holding RSC – for the stake in WLTC. An enti-



REUTERS

ty affiliated with the Trump family holds a 38% stake,” the *Journal* said, quoting a source.

Mr. Tahnoon and others had invested \$500 million in World Liberty Financial in January 2025. “The deal, signed four days before President Trump’s inauguration, steered \$263 million to Trump family entities, according to the President’s most recent financial disclosure,” the *Journal* noted.

A stablecoin is designed to maintain a stable value and reduce volatility. It is pegged to a currency, commodity or other asset, which may be held in reserve to back its value.

“USDI now has a market value of \$4 billion. World Liberty says the dollars backing USDI are invested in U.S. Treasury and other cash equivalents, generating an estimated \$150 million a year in interest,” the *Journal* reported.

Mr. Trump was not always fond of cryptocurrencies. During his first term, he bashed Facebook’s plans to create a digital cur-

rency. He dismissed Bitcoin and its peers as “not money,” calling their value “highly volatile and based on thin air”. In 2021, he told *Fox Business* that Bitcoin was a “scam”. “I think they should regulate them very, very high,” he said, adding, “It takes the edge off of the dollar and the importance of the dollar.”

Policy shift

That changed as the 2024 election approached. Crypto companies funnelled more than \$119 million into a non-partisan super PAC to elect pro-crypto candidates in that cycle, and Mr. Trump vowed to make the United States the “crypto capital of the planet”.

In March 2025, Mr. Trump created the U.S. Strategic Bitcoin Reserve by executive order, treating Bitcoin as a long-term reserve asset on par with gold. That July, he signed the GENIUS (Guiding and Establishing National Innovation for U.S. Stablecoins) Act, laying out regulatory guidelines for stablecoins.

Financial disclosures filed in June show he earned more than \$1.4 billion from his crypto ventures. Over \$500 million of it from World Liberty Financial, and another \$635 million from sales of his \$TRUMP meme coin. His reported income for the year was over \$2.2 billion, much higher than his 2024 income of \$600 million.

Founded in 2024, World Liberty Financial is at the heart of the Trump’s crypto empire. Its CEO Zach Witkoff, is the son of Mr. Trump’s West Asia envoy, Steve Witkoff. Other co-founders include Donald Trump Jr., Eric Trump, Barron Trump, Steve Witkoff, and the President himself. This arrangement could blur the line that separates governance and private financial interests. The Trump administration sets policy, and the President’s family and allies benefit financially.

Mr. Tahnoon’s investment is especially notable given the UAE’s position as a key U.S. partner in West Asia. Since the beginning of the U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran on February 28, Gulf countries have borne a significant share of Iran’s retaliatory attacks, with the war also disrupting maritime traffic in the region.

These relationships raise fundamental questions: Can a sitting President accept investments from a foreign government official in his companies?

Smriti Sudesh

“We are taking the first step on a thousand-kilometre road. We are taking a step towards democracy for everyone,” Abdullah Ocalan said in early August.

The remarks by the Kurdistan Workers’ Party (PKK) leader, who has been in prison since 1999, came at an important moment as Türkiye attempts to end its long-running conflict with Kurdish minority militants.

The latest development came on August 24, when a Monitoring and Evaluation Board set up to oversee the process held its first meeting. The Board, chaired by Vice-President Cevdet Yilmaz, brought together senior officials including Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan, Defence Minister Yasar Guler and National Intelligence Organisation chief Ibrahim Kalin. It decided to set up four working groups dealing with legal issues, disarmament, monitoring, and the social reintegration of former militants.

The move is significant because the process is now moving beyond declarations. Several attempts to bring peace in the past remained unsuccessful; most recently in 2015.

A new law passed by Parliament on August 10, as part of that effort, was approved by 468 of the 592



REUTERS

lawmakers who voted.

The law provides conditional amnesty measures for people accused or convicted of offences linked to the PKK, including membership, assisting the organisation, spreading propaganda, and financing terrorism. It could pave the way for thousands of militants to return to Türkiye and reintegrate into society. The government, meanwhile, has stressed that it is not a general amnesty.

For those covered by the law, prison sentences can be suspended and ongoing investigations and trials can be put on hold for five to 10 years. If no terrorism-related offences are committed during that period, the suspended sentences would be considered served and pending cases would be dropped.

There are clear limits, however. Those convicted of intentional killings are excluded. So are people sentenced to life imprisonment without parole for offences committed before 2005. That is particularly significant for Mr. Ocalan.

Despite being a central figure in the current peace process, he would not benefit from the new law. Mr. Yilmaz said Mr. Ocalan’s case “does not fall within the scope of this law”, but added that he could remain “in a position to contribute to the peace process”.

The PKK has called the legislation a “beginning” but said it contains “serious shortcomings and deficiencies”. It has also demanded Mr. Ocalan’s release, stating that the process can move forward only if he “lives and works freely”.

A long conflict

The PKK began its armed insurgency against the Turkish state in 1984, seeking self-rule for Kurds inside Türkiye. Over the next four decades, the conflict killed more than 40,000 people, devastated parts of south-eastern Türkiye and became one of the defining issues of Turkish politics. The PKK is designated as a terrorist organisation by Türkiye, the United States

and the European Union.

The current attempt at a settlement began taking shape in 2024, when Ankara opened a new channel of dialogue with the Kurdish movement.

Later in February 2025, Mr. Ocalan called on the PKK to lay down its arms and dissolve. The group announced its dissolution in May, formally ending its armed campaign. In July, the disarmament process began with a symbolic ceremony in northern Iraq, where PKK burned their weapons. Since then, Ankara has been building the legal and institutional framework around what the government calls “Terror-Free Türkiye”.

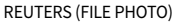
His February call made him an important channel of communication between the organisation and Ankara. The DEM Party, Türkiye’s main Kurdish political movement, has also helped facilitate communication between Mr. Ocalan and the government.

The immediate challenge now is to see how the law will come into force. The measures will take effect only after Türkiye’s National Security Council – chaired by President Recep Tayyip Erdogan – confirms that the PKK has dissolved and surrendered its weapons. The Council is expected to consider findings from Turkish security institutions at its October meeting.

Iceland votes in tight referendum on restarting EU membership talks



Niger's junta says back in control after gunfire, clashes rock capital



French far-right says Left plans to disrupt 'civil peace' if Le Pen wins



Colombian forces nab suspected senior Tren de Aragua gang leader



A BM-BME

LOOKING AT POSITIVES

The team effort is going to take the players a long way: Prasidh



PTI

The ones who played [against Sri Lanka] obviously got the credit that they were due. But all the reserves out there... running in and helping all of us. This effort is going to take us all a long way. This is the way the team has to be run — India pacer Prasidh Krishna to his teammates after the Test series.

ARCHER'S VIEW

‘It’s nice having extra seamers in the team, I could play until I’m 40’



AP

Jofra Archer said he might play till he turns 40, thanks to the benefits of being a member of England's pace quartet. Archer, Robinson, Tongue and Atkinson have all featured in the side in the series against Pakistan. "It's nice having the extra seamers in the line-up. I could play until I'm 40 at this rate," said the 31-year-old.

MIXED BAG

South Africa loses to Namibia, but bounces back against Zimbabwe



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

South Africa suffered an 18-run defeat against host Namibia in the opening match of the tri-series at Windhoek on Friday. However, the Proteas beat Zimbabwe on Saturday. **The scores: Saturday:** Zimbabwe 144/8 in 20 overs lost to South Africa 146/3 in 13.4 overs; **Friday:** Namibia 163/9 in 20 overs bt South Africa 145/9 in 20 overs.

RIGHT CHOICE

Mourinho feels Mbappe should be given the Ballon d'Or this year



REUTERS

Real Madrid coach Jose Mourinho said Kylian Mbappe deserves to win this year's Ballon d'Or, arguing that the award should go to "the best player in the world" rather than be decided by World Cup or Champions League success. "For me, there is one who made history this summer," said Mourinho, referring to Mbappe.



On top of the world: Argentina scored a late equaliser and went on to prevail in penalties. AP

Argentina breaks Dutch hearts in a shootout

Granatto finds the equaliser for the South Americans in the 53rd minute after Jansen opens the scoring for Netherlands; Cosentino saves two penalties before Cairo's goal seals the deal

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

On a chilly summer evening at the Wa-gener Stadion, Argentina's women had their own Maracanazo moment. Netherlands does not lose often. In the last 13 years, it has lost just one game a year while lifting three successive World Cups. On Saturday, too, Netherlands was on the verge of winning before Argentina struck late to hold it to a 1-1

draw. The Argentines went on to dethrone the Dutch in a penalty shootout. It was doubly sweet for the South American nation as it avenged its 2022 final loss while also silencing a partisan home crowd at one of the cathedrals of the sport. After Cristina Cosentino saved two Netherlands penalties, Sofia Cairo made it 3-1 when she put the ball in the net and sparked celebrations in the Argentina camp. In a highly anticipated rematch, both teams struggled to impose themselves

in open play as they looked overawed by the occasion. It was left to the talismanic dragflickers to have their say in penalty corners. It needed 30 minutes for the first one to arrive. Yibbi Jansen didn't even need a sighter and the tournament's top-scorer sounded the boards to hoist the lead for the host. In response, Argentina's penalty corner set-up squandered four chances in the third quarter. But, the South Americans continued to push on through Cairo, whose snaking runs into the circle

troubled the home side's defence and earned many penalty corners. With seven minutes to go, Argentina opted for a variation. Agustina Gorzelany fired her dragpush into the path of a teammate, who deflected the ball to an unmarked Maria Granatto for the equaliser. In the third-place play-off, co-host Belgium beat Australia 1-0 through a goal from Charlotte Engelbert. **The result (final):** Netherlands 1 (Yibbi Jansen 30-pc) drew with Argentina 1 (Maria Granatto 53-pc). Argentina won 3-1 on penalties.

The siblings are having a grand year on chess tour

P.K. Ajith Kumar

They are the world's first brother-sister Grandmaster duo. And this is turning out to be their grandest year on the chessboard. R. Praggnanandhaa and R. Vaishali have already recorded some of their finest performances this year. How Vaishali won the Candidates tournament after starting out as the eight seed in a field of eight in Cyprus in April has been the biggest story of the year in women's chess so far.

She became the first Indian woman to win the Candidates and will now play China's Ju Wenjun for the World championship. Koneru Humpy is the only Indian to have contested the Women's World championship.

After her greatest moment, Vaishali had told this correspondent over the phone from Cyprus how helpful the presence of her younger brother was at the Candidates tournament. Personally for Praggnanandhaa, it was a tournament to forget, though: in the open event he finished seventh.

But the gritty fighter that he is, he has battled



Family affair: Pragg and Vaishali will be part of India's challenge at the Olympiad in Samarkand. FILE PHOTO

his way back to top form since. During the last three months, he has won as many major titles — Norway Chess, where he stunned the World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen twice, the Saint Louis Rapid & Blitz and then the Grand Chess Tour, in the finals of which he outwitted the World No. 2 Fabiano Caruana just a couple of days ago at St. Louis.

Vaishali was also in the American city alongside Praggnanandhaa, but she

didn't have a great time, though. She was there for the Cairns Cup. They would soon be travelling together for a much bigger event. The Chess Olympiad, to be held at Samarkand next month, will see them representing India. And they could have key roles to play in India's title defence. At the last Olympiad in Budapest in 2024, India was crowned champion in both the open and women's sections.

England pulls away further at Lord's

Associated Press
LONDON

England extended its lead over Pakistan in the second Test to 342 as it reached 162 for six at tea on a rain-hit third day at Lord's on Saturday. England's bid for victory had been delayed with no play possible on Saturday morning at the home of cricket because of showers. The hosts resumed in the afternoon at 81 for three in their second innings. By tea, after more time was lost due to rain, England had doubled its total to 162 and lost three more wickets.

Abbas takes three

Emilio Gay (31) was trapped leg-before by Mohammad Abbas and Harry Brook (34) was caught behind after a 45-run stand for the fifth wicket with Dan Lawrence. Abbas dismissed Jamie Smith (7) for his third wicket.

England, which won the first Test by an innings at Headingley last week, is looking to clinch the three-match series.

The scores: England 290 & 162/6 in 44.3 overs vs. Pakistan 110 at tea.

Semifinals promise much as Central battles East and South spars with North

DULEEP TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

The cream of Indian cricket's second rung will be in action as the 2026-27 Duleep Trophy semifinal fixtures get underway at the BCCI Centre of Excellence from Sunday. Defending champion Central Zone will take on East while last season's finalist South Zone will spar with North. East and North notched up contrasting victories in the quarterfinals. Where East, marshalled by Ishan Kishan, recorded a thumping innings and 210-run win over North East, Kanhaiya Wadhawan's North conjured a dramatic 52-run success despite West Zone coasting at 195 for three while chasing 287. Teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi could only score eight runs for East but picked up two wickets with his left-arm spin in the second essay. The last-four clash will offer him another opportunity at bettering his middling First Class numbers (215 runs from 13 innings at average of 16.53). Keeping him silent will be high on Central skipper



Key players: While Vaibhav, who has picked up wickets, will look to better his batting record, Abid will aim to carry on his good form with the ball. K. MURALI KUMAR, ALLEN EGENUSE J.

Rajat Patidar's priorities, and it remains to be seen if off-spinner Saransh Jain can aid him in this. Saransh is part of the roster but made his India debut in the second Test against Sri Lanka in Colombo, which kept him on the field until Thursday. But fellow India international Gurnoor Brar — who didn't play either Test in Sri Lanka — has been added to the North Zone squad and participated in Saturday morning's practice. His entry further bolsters North's pace attack, for it already has Anshul Kamboj and Arshdeep Singh.



Jammu & Kashmir left-arm spinner Abid Mushtaq starred in the win over West with a match-haul of nine for 99. Whether he gets the same purchase at CoE Ground 2 as he did on the red-soil wicket at Ground 1 will be intriguing to watch. South has a solid batting line-up, led by skipper Tilak Varma, R. Smaran — 2025-26 Ranji Trophy's leading scorer with 950 runs — and Karun Nair. There is also Shaik Rashed, the highly rated 21-year-old, who made 627 runs in Andhra's dash to the Ranji quarterfinals last season.

My best in terms of quality and consistency: Velavan

SQUASH

K. Keerthivasan
CHENNAI

Sparring with World No. 15 Mohamed ElShorbagy and World No. 22 Baptiste Ma-sotti under the watchful eyes of French coach Gregory Gaultier in Prague over the last few weeks has made India's Velavan Senthilkumar a more solid and consistent player. The 28-year-old's preparation ahead of the new season paid handsome dividends as he clinched his maiden PSA World Tour title at the Budapest Open on Friday. In the Copper event, the World No. 54 defeated Hungary's Balazs Farkas 11-4, 11-2, 11-3 in the final to bag his 11th PSA crown. On winning the biggest trophy of his career yet, Velavan said: "This is the best I've played in terms of the quality of squash and the consistency I displayed." Working with Gaultier, a former World No. 1, and Saurav Ghosal helped him immensely. "With Gaultier, I am putting in the hard yards and with Saurav, I am working on a few technical aspects," he said. Beating top seed Eain Yow Ng of Malaysia for the first time — in the last-eight stage — was a huge confidence booster for the Indian. "I have grown up with him playing the Asian juniors. This was my first win against him," he added. Velavan proved that the victory over the Malaysian was no flash in the pan as he defeated his compatriot and third seed Veer Chotrani in the semifinals. "That was another amazing match. I was



First of many? Velavan won his maiden PSA World Tour title on Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Joshna is the most experienced player in the Indian team. She knows all the subtleties of doubles. I am trying to learn from her

dence booster for the Indian. "I have grown up with him playing the Asian juniors. This was my first win against him," he added. Velavan proved that the victory over the Malaysian was no flash in the pan as he defeated his compatriot and third seed Veer Chotrani in the semifinals. "That was another amazing match. I was

down 8-10 in the fifth game. Eventually winning it 12-10 was a really good indicator [of how I played]," he said. His ultimate goal is to break into the world's top 20 by the end of the season.

Excited

The southpaw is excited to play with Joshna Chinappa in mixed doubles at the Asian Games. "She is the most experienced player in the Indian team. She knows all the subtleties of doubles. I am trying to learn all of that from her," said Velavan, who had won bronze with Joshna at the Asian Doubles Championships in June.

Man City overruns Palace, Liverpool held

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Rayan Cherki proved his point to Enzo Maresca as the Manchester City star's brilliant double inspired a 4-1 rout of Crystal Palace on Friday. City boss Maresca admitted Cherki was frustrated to be left out of the starting line-up for last weekend's 2-1 win against Bournemouth in the Premier League opener. Cherki scored a brace after an own goal from City keeper Gianluigi Donnarumma had cancelled out Erling Haaland's opener in rainy south London. Haaland struck again in the closing stages to cap City's dominant display. In Saturday's early kickoff, Andoni Iraola escaped defeat on his Anfield debut as Liverpool manager thanks to Victor Munoz's strike to salvage a 2-2 draw against Nottingham Forest. Forest was set to win at

Anfield for the third consecutive season as Dan Ndoye and Morgan Gibbs-White's penalty twice put the visitors in front. Michael Olise and Luis Diaz were among five different goalscorers as Bayern Munich cruised to a 5-1 home win over Stuttgart in Friday's Bundesliga opener. **The results: Premier League:** Liverpool 2 (Isak 60, Munoz 82) drew with Nottingham Forest 2 (Ndoye 24, Gibbs-White 70-pen); Bournemouth 1 (Scott 41) drew with Everton 1 (Tarkowski 90+1); Coventry 0 lost to Hull 1 (Millar 82). **Bundesliga:** RB Leipzig 3 (Baku 25, Nusa 49, Reitz 66) bt Borussia M'Gladbach 0; Mainz 0 drew with Paderborn 0; Union Berlin 3 (Latte Lath 3, Querfeld 79, Skarke 90+2) drew with Eintracht Frankfurt 3 (Ebnoutalib 10, 11, 67); Elversberg 3 (Petkov 8, Campbell 9, Mokwa 46) bt Bayer Leverkusen 2 (Schick 77, Kofane 90+1). **On Friday: Premier League:** Crystal Palace 1 (Donnarumma 56-og) lost to Manchester City 4 (Haaland 17, 84, Cherki 54, 59). **Serie A:** AC Milan 2 (Ramos 69, Halhal 89-og) bt Venezia 0.



Two-goal hero: Cherki scores City's third against Palace. REUTERS



Clearing the way: Rescue workers and heavy machinery clear mud and debris in a flood-hit area of Nepal, after a devastating flash flood swept through villages in the northern part of the country.



Temporary refuge: A woman feeds a child at a relief camp in Nuwakot. Nepal's disaster authority said 4,451 people had been rescued so far and search operations are still on.



A trail of ruin: The remains of homes and other buildings are seen buried under mud and debris in a flood-hit area of Nepal.

Hope hangs in the skies



Prabhat Khanal

Rescue teams in Nepal's Nuwakot district are searching for people feared trapped in a blocked hydropower tunnel in Rasuwa, while families at relief camps wait anxiously for helicopters carrying their loved ones

In August 26, a catastrophic flash flood triggered by a high-altitude glacial collapse along the Nepal-Tibet border decimated the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli river corridors. The disaster heavily impacted multiple regions, completely devastating the Trishuli River basin and Bidur Municipality in Nuwakot district with extreme torrents and sudden landslides. Those rescued are constantly scanning the skies for helicopters, hoping they are bringing back family members who remain stranded in villages upstream. As floodwaters from the Bhotekoshi flowed into the Trishuli River, the sudden surge triggered landslides and widespread destruction downstream in Bidur Municipality and across Nuwakot district. The Nepal Army and Armed Police Force are trying to clear a blocked tunnel at a hydropower project in Rasuwa district, hoping to find people who may be trapped inside.



Emergency care: Nepali Army doctors treat a woman at a field hospital in Battar, Nuwakot, after she was rescued from the Bhotekoshi flood.



Into the field: Nepali Army rescue personnel head towards an airstrip near Nuwakot as teams remain on alert for further flooding after a debris dam burst on August 28.

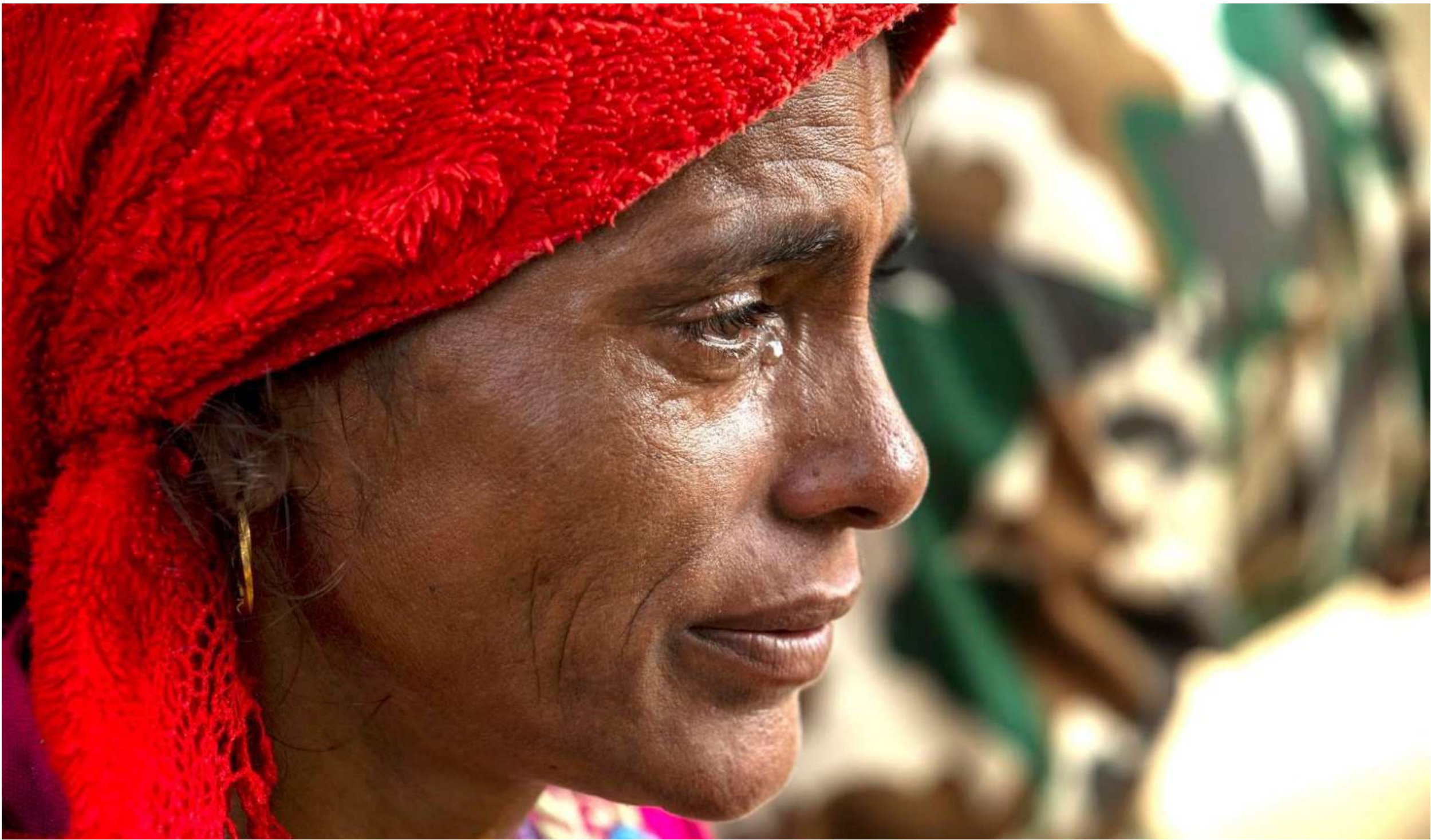


A long wait: Relatives search lists of missing people outside a hospital in Battar, Nuwakot, on August 28; at least 2,426 people remain missing.



Rescue under way: A helicopter flies rescue missions in Rasuwa district of Nepal where many people have been stranded.

Seeking answers: Relatives give the names of missing family members to officials as the search for survivors continues; among those out of contact are hundreds of foreign nationals.



Tears of relief: A woman becomes emotional at a Nepali Army camp in Nuwakot after being rescued, as her injured husband is taken to Kathmandu for treatment. Her family, originally from western Nepal, ran a hotel in Rasuwa.

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